

The Craft of Ritual Studies

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https://doi.org/10.1093/acprof:oso/9780195301427.001.0001

Published: 28 November 2013 **Online ISBN:** 9780199369164 **Print ISBN:** 9780195301427

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CHAPTER

9 Elements of Ritual

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https://doi.org/10.1093/acprof:oso/9780195301427.003.0010 Pages 231–293

Published: 28 November 2013

Abstract

Ritual is conceptualized as factorable into constituents: actions, actors, places, times, objects, languages, and groups. If one thinks of the whole statically, together these constitute ritual "structures." If one imagines dynamically, they are "processes."

Keywords: actions, actors, places, times, objects, languages, groups, structures, processes, elements, domains

Subject: Sociology and Anthropology of Religion

Collection: Oxford Scholarship Online

Suppose you've written a book designed around this single-sentence definition (a worthy exercise but risky venture): In rituals sensorily engaged participants congregate in selected places to bide their time artfully cultivating attitudes conducive to enacting their core values. Let's boldly imagine that a press has bought into your plan and you've hired an artist to paint your kingpin definition into an illustrative cover design; you've done your homework and know the press would never pay for such an extravagance. She slogs through your carefully wrought (she does not say "tortured") prose, making notes and posing questions (see list 10), to help transform your abstraction into an image capable of enticing a reader to pick up, buy, and read, thereby keeping you in the business of thinking and writing.[396]

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List 10. An Artist's Notes for a Cover Design

- Participants: Who is coming?
- Sensorily engaged: What actions do they perform that might keep their attention?
- Congregate: What groups form? Who is related to whom?
- Selected places: Where does the event take place? What is possible in the available space?
- Biding time: In what time period is the event set? How long does it last?
- Artfully cultivating attitudes: What is the tone of the event? Which arts contribute to the event? What kind of food, and how much?
- Conducive to enacting: What do the figures on the cover expect to happen? What are the main activities? Who does what? Who says what?
- Core values: What matters most in this event? What ritual work needs doing here? What's peripheral, and what's "to die for"?

The artist may not think of these as discrete "parts" of the whole scene, and even if she did, she might well design the painting so they overlap and interact. Even so, each aspect of your idea has to be put somewhere in her painting, so she momentarily fractures the whole into its constituent factors so she can artfully recombine
p. 232 them. Why? Because her brain, like yours and mine, depends on part-whole ↳ thinking. Creating, an act of synthesis, requires analysis, the act of pulling apart a thing in search of its constituents. Imagine stretching a piece of fabric to see its threads. What are the "threads" of this ritual? she asks. What is the smallest unit of study or construction? What is the largest unit? What constitutes an entire ritual? Where and when does it begin and end? What are the mediating structures or processes that knit the elements of a ritual into whole cloth?

I call the smallest unit of ritual studies research an element, as if a rite can be factored into its constituents. Using a notion from math, you could say ritual is the product, rather than the sum, of these factors. Using an idea from chemistry, you might imagine a periodic table of the elements as long as you realize that ritual elements do not exist in nature; they are cultural or scholarly constructions.

Whether for artistic or scholarly reasons, rituals can be disassembled, and they can be cobbled together. Stitched in tandem (imagine a team of horses pulling a two-wheeled buggy), rituals ramify into systems and traditions. Ritual traditions and ritual systems are two sides of the same coin, the same thing conceived from different perspectives, each a corrective to the other. A ritual system is a synchronic, dynamic, interacting whole. A ritual tradition is diachronic, emerging, developing, and declining through time, its duration quite long or very brief.

By this division of labor, a ritual is a midlevel unit, from which a student of ritual can shift attention to either small-scale micro units (elements) or large-scale macro units (traditions or systems). Like any whole—a person, a planet, or ecosystem—a ritual exceeds the sum of its parts. Without one of its parts it may not function properly. However much you may worry that "parts" is a mechanistic metaphor, makers and interpreters (not to mention cover designers) find themselves making lists of props and participants, implying that the whole of a ritual includes parts even if people might not agree on how to conceive or name them.

Ideally, you as a ritual studies scholar wish to do it all: analyze the parts of a ritual, synthesize a model of one, map its cultural location, lay out its system, trace its tradition, plumb its depths, and explain its dynamics. In actuality, we merely human ritual studies scholars are forced to focus our research by foregrounding some things and backgrounding others. Rendering something as background, or context, actively shapes how you

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interpret a focalized object. The focal metaphor suggests that a background does not disappear even when it goes out of focus. If you focus on a ritual performance, its constituent elements and the system in which it is embedded may momentarily drop into the background.

Rituals are designed assemblages. Something is designed when it is planned and constructed in a way that enables form and dynamic to follow one another. When something is skillfully designed, its form and dynamic are well "attuned"; the interaction is "choreographic." However, an assemblage is a sculptural technique of composing a group of unrelated, fragmentary, or discarded objects into a work of art. There is a certain randomness or uselessness to an assemblage. Rituals show signs of both, design and assemblage.

p. 233 Regardless of whether your intentions are constructive or analytical, ritual studies scholars must eventually think about forms and dynamics, as well as part-whole relations. You can imagine elemental units in a variety of ways. Imagined chemically, combining the two elements hydrogen and oxygen creates water. Imagined mechanically, assembling a box of parts, if they are the right ones and you know what you are doing, can produce a bicycle. But more than assembly is required even for a bike. It is still necessary to pedal your way home, so you need to know how to balance something that rolls on two wheels. If anything goes wrong, you will need to understand how bikes work: The foot, by exerting pressure on the pedals, drives the chainwheel around, which transfers the force to the rear hub, which exerts torque on the rear wheel … and since the chain came off … In short, you have to take account of not only parts and wholes but also dynamics.

Some castigate the notion of an "element" or "part" on the grounds that it mechanizes and reifies ritual.[397] A ritual, you are sometimes instructed, is an event, not an object. True enough, but I still find mechanistic metaphors useful, and they show up everywhere, for instance, when a writer refers to rituals as being constructed of "building blocks."[398] Critics may be able to dispense with the "part" metaphor when theorizing, but they are less likely to do so when constructing a ritual. Getting rid of the idea of parts is as difficult as dispensing with the term "ritual" if that's what you want to study. I continue to use "element" and "part" as theoretically useful metaphors, although they are not to be literalized or died for.

Thinking of a ritual as containing elements or as being contained by an ambient culture arises in part because of the Western predilection for container metaphors. I imagine ritual as floating in its matrix, or ambient culture. However, it should be no surprise that stuff "out there," say, politics and economics, leaks into "here," the precincts of the ritual you're studying. The container analogy is imperfect, because culture is not only ambient; it also permeates a ritual. Culture is not only "around" a ritual but also "in" a ritual, forcing us to inquire into a ritual's permeability as well as its insularity: What kinds of entries and exits are facilitated by this ritual? What kinds are blocked?

Since we Westerners think habitually with container metaphors, we should pay attention to what we're doing. There is nothing natural or universal in conceiving of ritual this way. Even in the postindustrial West, container metaphors have their limits. Container metaphors may help visualize part-whole relationships, but, because they are static, they are less effective at helping us imagine how things move or interact. For this task, we sometimes resort to dynamics metaphors. Dynamics are the rules governing a system of interacting forces. Based on mechanics and physics, dynamics theories construe rituals as having the capacity to move or do things, as exercising power.

Another frequently invoked option is organic metaphor, of which there are many variations. The most popular one conceives ritual as a collective "body." This collective body contains individual bodies connected by …
p. 234 something. This something is ↳ variously named "culture," "society," the "collective unconscious," and so on. Recently this organic whole has been imagined as a spider's web or an energy network. But it is worth noticing that even organically conceived rituals typically smuggle in container metaphors and analogies from physics and electronics.

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Like all metaphors, mechanical and organic ones are enlightening in some ways and blinding in others. Even if one prefers to imagine a ritual as an organic, collective body, there is no good reason to avoid also thinking of it mechanically. In fact, playing organic and mechanical conceptions off each other can prevent us from literalizing either. A rite is not a body or spider's web any more than it is a bike or pressure cooker. Either way, a ritual, if it works, is a set of interconnected processes working in an integrated, dynamic fashion.

Although rites are not bikes, for the purpose of ritual construction it can be useful to think of rituals mechanistically.[399] Anyone who has ever made or conducted a ritual knows that it implies parts, some tangible, some not: people, bowls, books, words spoken, actions enacted, spaces set up. From parts to a parts list is a short leap, often made. Especially long or complex rituals may require entire books to supplement the flagging memories of participants. If you are a ritual leader, you forget key parts of a ritual at your peril. In addition to costumes made, scripts written, and lighting properly aligned, there are places to be rented and food to be prepared. You effectively exercise ritual leadership by knowing how to make good use of the nuts, bolts, and wheels of ritual. In addition to sheer, countable properties, there are spatial divisions that may require enumerating: entryway, central space, exit; floor, ceiling, walls. Even the temporal phases of a ritual—minimally, a beginning, middle, and end—are modular units of design. Likewise the intangibles: First people should feel welcomed, then included, then challenged, and finally, they should depart feeling joyful (or sad, if it's a funeral). Even though you might insist that joy is not a thing, if it's not there, you'll likely be heard muttering, "Joy was missing" as if it were.

Ritual parts, like body and bike parts, are interconnected, and it is not always easy to tell where one ends and the other begins. In bodily systems there are mediating structures—neurons, tendons, and ligaments—so it may be hard to tell exactly where the upper arm and lower arm or the brain and nerves begin and end. They are systematically interconnected. The risk of speaking about a ritual "system" is imagining it as self-sufficient, sealed off from the rest of the world, when, in fact, it is not. Claiming that a ritual is systemic does not mean that it is disconnected from everything else, that everything about it works well, or that everything in it is consistent with every other thing. A bike is a mechanical system, but you can ride one with a flat tire or without fenders. Likewise, rites can work even when some parts are "broken."

Doing an elemental analysis of a ritual serves ritual theory as well as it does ritual construction. One reason for analyzing a ritual into elements is to resist oversimplification. Analysis forces you to notice a ritual's
p. 235 complexity, to understand how each ↳ element contributes to, or detracts from, the whole. Planned or analyzed in detail, a ritual unfolds, becoming far more complex than formal definitions might lead you to believe. Another reason for analysis is to assist in noticing ritual transformations: What was an entryway on one occasion is made into an exit on another. What looks at first like the ending of a ceremony becomes, on a second look, a new beginning. What looks linear from one participant's perspective appears recursive from someone else's.

Tracking the details of a ritual has an effect similar to that of transcribing, word for word, the stories or views of an interviewee. The task is laborious and time-consuming, but there is no other way to grasp their nuance and texture. Probing a ritual's elements and dynamics, we uncover subspaces and notice subphases. To treat a ritual as having elements is a formalist tactic, drawing attention to the form, or design, of a ritual, staving off premature leaps to the whole ritual's social or ecological functions.[400] Functional considerations are necessary, but not at the expense of formalist ones. The two require each other.

In any case, I should no longer postpone the act of carving the carcass of ritual. (I multiply metaphors so no one, including me, is tempted to seize on any one of them as sacred.) If you skin the organically grown, grain-fed turkey of ritual, where does the knife go? How might you divide it up?

Figure 9.1 schematizes the elements of ritual as a set of overlapping spheres floating in a limitless sea of social context, two areas of which have been singled out and numbered, thereby selected for analysis. One context

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might, for instance, be other rituals in the same system, in which case a student of ritual might examine how one element, say a hymn, migrates from ritual A to ritual B. Another context might be, say, the local economic
p. 236 system and its bearing on who benefits financially ↳ from the fact that the ritual you're studying endures. My assumption is not only that parts make up the whole but that they do so dynamically, by interacting: Ritual language interacts with ritual time, transforming it in its interaction with ritual objects, and so on. As each element does what it is designed to do, the dynamics become increasingly complex. If an element is poorly designed, well, things may grind to a halt and the poor riders will just have to limp along.

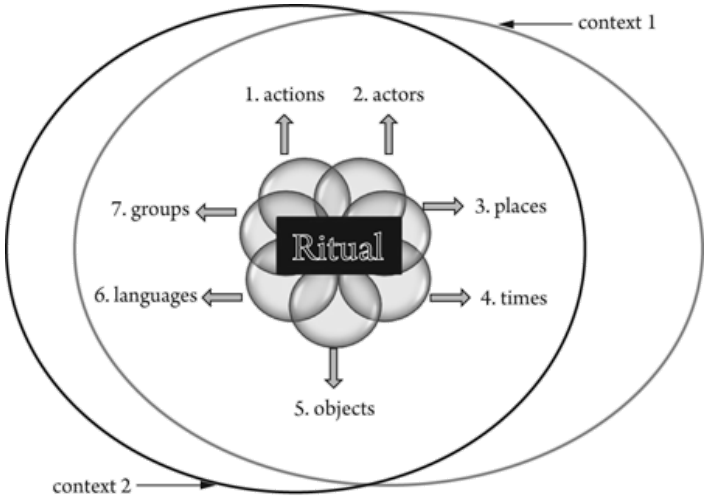


Figure 9.1. Elements of Ritual, Simplified

Probably you will not be surprised if I say that one can carve up the sacrificial bird of ritual into other parts, naming them in alternative ways. Maybe you are already sketching your own elemental scheme in the margins. In other families or countries does Dad cut out the wishbone so the kids can squabble over it? Do they even call it a "wishbone"? When I've shown the diagram to others, asking what's missing, the responses have included: "Where's the music and food and costumes? What about feelings, don't they matter? Beliefs, hmmm, are they held by actors or by institutions?" No matter how many elements, and no matter how they are named, if students of ritual were to export the scheme to multiple cultures, trying to use it to analyze an ancient Coptic or a contemporary Javanese ritual, they would discover what they already know: There are many ways to carve a turkey. No one except your father says you *must* carve the beast in *this* way. You would discover other, non-English terms for the parts of a ritual, and you would encounter participants who feel no desire at all to name them.

The chart is merely one way of marshaling a minimal vocabulary to facilitate scholarly discussion. If nothing else, it can serve as a prompt for researchers to ask: How do participants in the ritual I'm studying disarticulate the beast? What parts do they name, and what parts do they leave unnamed? Does a ritual costume, for instance, count as part of the ritual actor who wears it, or should it be numbered among ritual objects? And are objects that act best treated as objects or as subjects? Is a musical score an object or a kind of language calling for a set of actions?

There is nothing sacrosanct about the diagram; it is a starting point, a tool for getting the work of analyzing ritual started. The scheme's constructedness can be rendered obvious by recounting a bit of its revision history. At one time, for example, "Attitudes" was a category alongside "Actors" and "Actions." At another, "Actors" included "Actions" and "Attitudes." "Groups" was not one of the original categories, and "Texts" were once among the "Objects." The distinctions are not quite arbitrary, but neither are they natural or universal. They are academic improvisations, highly dependent on purpose and situation. I assume their critique and further

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development. More fully unpacked into a chart of considerations and questions, the elements look like they do in table 9.1.

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Table 9.1. Elements of Ritual, Expanded

Elementsfl	Considerations	Sample Research Questions
1. Ritual Actions	• the ritual event, the whole rite, the "plot" of the action as it moves from beginning through middle to end	What constitutes "the ritual"? How is it named? Are some actions more essential than others? What actions are variable? Not? What actions merely facilitate (rather than constitute) the ritual? What actions can be subtracted? Added? What types of activity can participants identify? How did this ritual come into being? What is this ritual said to do? What does it, in fact, do? Does it transform? Confirm? Enhance? Subvert? What happens after the ritual? What does the ritual effect? Ritually considered, what actions should one not do? How do participants perform ritual receptivity? What actions resemble or refer to other actions? Which, if any, actions are considered artistic? For participants, what are the categories, kinds, or genres of action?
	• constituent actions that make up the ritual, their phasing, rhythm, and style, the connections or disconnections among them, habitual vectors of bodily movement	
	• genres and styles of action, their form, medium, pacing, mood, tone	
	• facilitating, preparatory, or behind-the-scenes actions, clean-up and take-down activities	
	• influences on the actions, precedents, causal forces, and covariants (actions that vary in tandem with other actions)	
	• reactions, or responses, to the ritual, consequential actions, functions of the ritual	
	• actions that change things, actions that keep things the same	
	• acts of avoidance, actions avoided	
	• acts of receptivity, instances of passivity	

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	• actions that mirror or allude to other actions, mimesis	
	• artistic actions, e.g., singing, dancing	
	• the framing of the ritual, its social-cultural placement, taken-for-granted assumptions about it, definition of the ritual situation	
2. Ritual Actors	• bodies in motion, bodily comportment	Who enacts? Who witnesses? Of what does a person consist? Is the body valued, devalued, ignored? What parts of the bodily are emphasized? Which senses are emphasized? Deemphasized? Which senses are linked, the one activating the other? What kinds of movement are valued? Avoided? Which actors perform alone? Together? Who can change the ritual? Who resists change? How is agency understood? Is there a human/nonhuman divide? A natural/supernatural divide? What do participants understand a person, especially a ritually engaged person, to be? How do ritual agents act outside of ritual circumstances? Who evaluates the ritual? Offers interpretations of it? Tells stories about it? How significant is the interiority of ritualists? What do participants say are their aims? What motives and goals are implied by their actions? What are practitioners expected to believe? How much does belief matter? What attitudes are cultivated? Discouraged? Which are precluded from ritual? Which are shared? Public? Private?
	• persons performing gestures and postures	
	• the senses, sensing, sensory preferences	
	• ritual actors' self-awareness and other-awareness	
	• participants' personal feelings, attitudes, values, beliefs, purposes (explicit and conscious), intentions (tacit, preconscious)	
	• identities, personal and collective, of ritual participants	
	• ritual agents constructing, enacting, maintaining, and revising rites	
	• ritualists' attribution of agency to non-human ritual actors	
	• ritual actors entering and exiting rituals	

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	• ritually inflected behavior outside of ritualistic circumstances	
	• participants interpreting, evaluating, and talking about rituals	
3. Ritual Places	• sacred places, nonsacred places, special places	Which places are special or sacred? Which ones are not? Special how? Who sits beside whom? Who walks behind whom? Who or what is placed next to whom or what? Do directions matter? Why? Which ones do not? Is land bought and sold? Protected? What does the cosmos of this ritual include? Exclude? What things are used as sets? Are they built? Taken down? Destroyed? Reused? Is this an indoor or outdoor ritual? What would happen if it were moved? How placeless or place-specific is the ritual? What are the operative spatial distinctions (center/periphery, up/down, at home/in exile, etc.)?
	• proper placement, positioning, geographical and cosmological orientations; spatial contiguity	
	• land, nature, cosmos	
	• sets, settings, backdrop, backstage	
	• off-limits or dangerous places	
	• natural and constructed places	
	• indoor and outdoor places	
	• symbolic positions and prepositions: above/below, center/periphery, up/down, open/closed, private/public	
4. Ritual Times	• duration, phasing, rhythm	How does time unfold within the ritual itself? To what times does the ritual refer or allude? Are there special, or sacred, seasons? Are there down times? Ordinary times? Is there a ritual calendar? Are some eras valued over others? What is the shape of time, e.g., circular or linear? Does duration matter? Why? How are past and future ritually construed? How are the beginning and end imagined? How "big" is the present? What constitutes bad timing? Good timing? What kinds of time are reckoned? Who keeps time? Which transitions are marked? Which are not? How are past, present, and future conceived and attended to (or disregarded) in ritual?
	• kinds of time, e.g., ordinary and special, lunar/solar	
	• seasons	
	• cycles, life cycles	
	• eras	
	• the beginning of time, the end of time	

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	• temporal markers in the ritual	
	• tradition, accumulation across time	
	• timing, appropriateness	
	• calendrical time, clock time, experienced time	
	• tenses, tense usage	
5. Ritual Objects	• properties, material culture, possessions	What things are alive? Not alive? Do the dead act? Can things be persons? Can persons be things? What can be owned? Not? How is wealth counted? Of what does poverty consist? Who makes what? Who is custodian of what? What are the classes and kinds of things? What is treasured? What is trash? What is disposable? What, if any, objects are venerated? Who dresses up? How? On what occasions? How integral is costume to office? To personhood? What is edible and not? What foods become offerings?
	• classes of things: distinctions, divisions, dualisms: owned/not owned, inherited/bought, made/found, animate/inanimate, valuable/valueless, treasure/trash, displayed/hidden	
	• the construction, preservation, and disposition of ritual paraphernalia	
	• costume, dress, e.g., masks, clerical garb	
	• art objects, e.g., paintings, sculpture	
	• edible things, foodstuffs	
7. Ritual Languages	• nonlinguistic utterances, e.g., speaking in tongues	How valued, or not valued, is speech? What are the kinds of ritually significant language, e.g., myth, testimony, oratory, narrative, poetry, prayer, praise, ecstatic sounds, animal sounds? What forms do they take? Where and when are they are encouraged or discouraged? Which are cultivated? Devalued? What is said? Written? Read? Sung? Which rituals, or parts of ritual, are scripted? Are there secret or hidden scripts? What ritual knowledge is only passed on orally? Who can interpret? Who does not? When is critique allowed? Inhibited? How are ritual texts handled? What is theorized? Not? Is the ritual language considered sacred? Archaic? Are there official, or canonical, statements of belief? A written or codified ethic?
	• things said and words sung during ritual performance	
	• words that do things (performative utterances)	

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	• words, written or spoken, that facilitate the rite, e.g., texts, scripts, scenarios, rubrics, instructions	
	• backstage and pre-ritual talk	
	• words after or about the rite, e.g., interpretation, exegesis, criticism, theorizing	
	• oral teaching about ritual	
	• linguistic genres, kinds/ways of speaking regarding ritual	
	• texts, writing, books, libraries, and other sources of ritual knowledge	
	• views of language, uses of archaic or languages	
	• expressions of belief, creeds, worldviews	
8. Ritual Groups	• ritual groups and organizations	What social distinctions or discriminations are in force? Which ones count most? Least? Which distinctions are most powerfully reinforced by the ritual? What institutions and organizations sustain the ritual? Who acts? Individuals? Groups? How are individuals and groups orchestrated? How are individuality and selfhood viewed? What social roles are named? Valued? Devalued? What cultural domains are recognized? Which domains are densest with ritual? Which are least ritually significant? Which values are reinforced by the ritual?
	• social distinctions, e.g., gender, class, ethnicity, age; the ritual buttressing or subversion of these; inclusion and exclusion	
	• collective ideas, worldviews, attitudes—both espoused and implied	
	• values or virtues, e.g., kindness, bravery, generosity, truthfulness	
	• vices, taboos, things forbidden or rejected	

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• means of transmitting values and practices
• the politics and economics of ritual
• collective and individual agency
• ritual hierarchy, power, equality
• ritual leaders, ritual followers, facilitators
• ritual's relation to various cultural domains, e.g., politics, arts, medicine

The most important feature of this table is not how it names the categories, because you will likely recast them when studying a specific ritual. Rather, the table's importance is twofold. First, it schematizes the whole and its parts without predetermining which elements are most important or how they interact. Interactional priorities
p. 237 among the elements should not be predetermined by theory but inferred ↳

p. 238 ↳

p. 239 ↳

p. 240 ↳

p. 241 ↳

p. 242 ↳
from observing specific cases. Second, the questions signal the importance of persistent, systematic querying. Question-asking takes priority over category-formation, because the former is the basis of the latter. The main purpose of the list of elements is not to help scholars file things or catalog books but to provoke questions.[401] Whether one classifies Mount Rushmore Monument as a stone object, collective sacred personage, or institutional logo is less important than how one queries it.

Ritual Actions

Analyzing a ritual can begin with any element, say, a place or an object. In the archaeological study of ritual these may be the only possible places to begin. Archaeologists studying ritual have to infer both actors and actions from remains. Although places and things may accompany or facilitate a ritual, they rarely drive one. An exception might be pilgrimage to a sacred place in order to view our touch a sacred object. Without further study it would be impossible to say whether the going, touching, and returning, the place itself, or the object is central. Each requires the other.

Unless I have a good reason for doing otherwise, I begin with human interaction, bodies in motion, because they are what most often appear in a camera's viewfinder when shooting a ritual. Unless people tell me

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otherwise, I take actions to be the living, throbbing heart of the matter, and I assume that objects and places facilitate rather than constitute what they do.[402] Even if I do eventually discover that participants think a place or venerated object is the heart of the matter, I will likely have figured this out by watching or talking with the ritual actors. Choosing ritual action as the default starting point is both pragmatic and a reminder to focus on ritual. In any case, even if you begin with things or places, you eventually arrive at people acting, if you do your work thoroughly.

We can legitimately and usefully speak of "ritual actions," "ritual performances," "ritual enactments," "ritual practices," ritual behaviors," and "ritual events," depending on what we wish to emphasize. For example, although rituals are events—appearing, disappearing, and reappearing—they may also be based on or made into practices, repetitious attitude-building scenarios. A ritual performance is an evanescent social event. However long a ritual has persisted, and however often it is repeated, the performance of it begins and ends. People arrive at it and go home from it. Although a ritual may be enduring, it is not an object; you can't bounce it like a ball, deposit it in a bank, or ride it to work (no matter how often I have compared it to a bicycle). Ritual events, unlike ritual objects, tend to be pegged to bodily and cultural rhythms.

Things *move* but people *act*.[403] Human intention is what distinguishes action from movement. The most obvious thing about a ritual is that it consists of human actions (even if they are a response to something prior
p. 243 or more fundamental). ↳ Although these actions may be performed by individuals, more typically they are undertaken by groups. Because social density is so typical of ritual, ritual actions are usually *inter*actions, and these interactions differ in certain ways from ordinary kinds of interaction. Whether they differ so much that uninstructed outsiders can recognize them as ritualized is debatable. Perhaps, if those outsiders have witnessed enough ordinary interactions, they can perceive the differences, especially if costuming and high levels of stylization are involved. But if the observed ritual is mainly a matter of proper intention, as it is when Zen Buddhists clean house, then probably not. Without instruction, a student of ritual might confuse ritual actions with other kinds, such as dramatic ones. Suppose we witness people donning masks and walking down the street in odd ways. Is that clowning, possession, or drunk and disorderly behavior? In and of themselves, the formal characteristics of these actions do not tell us the answer.

Participants have their own vocabularies, and we students need to know them, but we need our own terms too. Often ordinary verbs suffice. In ordinary speech we talk about "doing" or "going to" a ritual. The first way of putting it emphasizes active participation; the second way is more passive. Theorists sometimes speak of ritual "performance," treating a ritual as "a showing of a doing."[404] Many rituals are showings, not only royal weddings but also private, ordinary ones. The groom wants to show his sincerity; the bride, her beauty; or vice versa, his beauty and her brains. In some traditions what one shows is not wealth and pageantry but simplicity, plainness. These actions too are not mere facts but the displaying of aspirations. When we speak of ritual as performance, we emphasize its ability to show forth.

Rituals may do more than show, however. For this reason I also use the term "enactment" when discussing ritual's distinctive kind of action. To enact is not only to do something in front of someone, but also to put into force. We enact legislation, taking it from being a mere recommendation to being "on the books." On the books, a law requires recognition and response. Similarly, enacting a ritual can set things in motion. Its gestures and postures are designed to achieve something. Their aim is not merely to entertain but rather to effect, so I usually say that people *enact* rituals, especially when a rite seems capable of accomplishing a deed or bringing about an effect. If I say "perform," it is usually to call attention to the fact of being witnessed by an audience or to an as-if attitude among participants. Ritual is *performed* when participants act in front of spectating others or when they play roles in a subjunctive mode.

Some scholars distinguish *action* from *behavior*, "behavior" connoting what can be observed, and "action" taking into account what actors intend. To my mind, these are two perspectives, emic and etic, on the same thing. "Behavior" objectifies and "action" does not. Although objectifying can be dehumanizing, objectification

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is a normal, necessary thing.[405] It is okay to objectify a person or a ritual, provided that is not the only thing you do to "it." By this usage, the more ritualists act predictably, the more they behave and the less they act.

p. 244 Some interpreters speak of ritual as *practice* rather than as action, enactment, or performance. Pierre Bourdieu, who has written the most insightfully on practice, treats it as complementary to rather than the opposite of performance or ritual. Performance theories usually hinge on one or two factors. Events are performative insofar as they have audiences (people are watching) or are framed as fictive (belief is not required). Practice theories focus instead on the ways cultural meanings seem natural, obvious, or taken for granted. Thus, the "practice" in "practice theory" is not quite like the "practice" in "baseball practice," since this kind of practice is preparatory for some other event, the game. Nor is it like the "practice" in "Buddhist practice," which is conscious and deliberate.

Bourdieu sometimes writes about especially elevated actions such as ritual, but the core of his theory is grounded in ordinary, practical activities such as eating and wearing clothes. His theory explains how societies reproduce their values in individuals, or, to put it another way, how individuals come habitually to hold the views and attitudes expected of them. *Habitus* is the name Bourdieu gives to this set of engrained dispositions that one begins imbibing at birth. He describes it variously as a "system of cognitive and motivating structures," "embodied history, internalized as a second nature," and "the persistence of the effects of primary conditioning."[406]

Unfortunately, Bourdieu tends to reify. He makes statements like, "The *habitus* tends to favor experiences likely to reinforce it" and "The habitus tends to protect itself from crises and critical challenges by providing itself with a milieu to which it is as pre-adapted as possible."[407] As a reminder to myself that he is talking about a process rather than an entity, I prefer to speak of "habituating" and "habituation" rather than "the habitus."[408]

Another key concept advanced by Bourdieu is that of a *field*, by which he does not mean either a place where wheat grows or a site to which ethnographically inclined researchers go when they want to observe other people's behavior. Although the term sounds spatial, it is not. Rather, a field is a set of interrelated actions in which people strive for advantage in their competition for limited goods. A field is less a place than the activity of contesting; it is the sort of behavior one expects in arenas.

Bourdieu calls the fundamental presuppositions of an interactive field its *doxa* (Greek for "belief" or "opinion"). "Doxa," he writes, "is the relationship of immediate adherence that is established in practice between a *habitus* and the field to which it is attuned, the pre-verbal taking-for-granted of the world that flows from practical sense."[409]

To return to the question "How is ritual action related to performance and to practice?," Bourdieu sometimes sounds as if he takes ritual to be the prime instance of habituation, or, if you prefer, the habitus. In one of his clearest statements about ritual, he observes,

> p. 245 Thus the attention paid to staging in great collective ceremonies derives not only from the concern to give a solemn representation of the group ↳ (manifest in the splendour of baroque festivals) but also, as many uses of singing and dancing show, from the less visible intention of ordering thoughts and suggesting feelings through the rigorous marshaling of practices and the orderly disposition of bodies, in particular the bodily expression of emotion.[410]

Bourdieu claims that placing bodies in prescribed postures re-evokes their associated feelings and states of mind. Because of the way rituals choreograph and classify, they create what he variously labels "deposits," "schemes," or "structures," which are sufficiently efficacious that bodies (read: people) come to take things for granted, a state more entrenched than merely believing. Regardless of whether one imagines ritual as depending on inherited deposits or re-created actions, Bourdieu thinks that knowledge passes among practitioners without the necessity for intervening, intermediary discourse or consciousness. The outcome is a

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seamless integration of bodily space with social and cosmic space.[411] In other words, he implies that people ritualize without thinking. My view: Although they *sometimes* do so, I do not think they *necessarily* do. In the video "Vespers in the City of New York," a group simultaneously practices and enacts a ritual.[412] Learning while doing, they halt, hesitate, and bump into each other as they try to learn the circle dance. They are also carrying pieces of paper, learning the lines of song and prayer. Even so, this *is* vespers, not merely preparation for it. It is practice in both senses of the term (see the glossary): actions preparatory to the performance of a ritual, as well as actions repeated for the sake of deepening a ritual's permeation of body and psyche. In "Enacting What We Say We Believe," Patrick Evans, the director of the vespers ritual, reflects on the process and even critiques it (see especially 51:51ff). Together the two videos pose a serious challenge to the assumption that people engaged in ritual practices cannot be thinking critically and analytically.

Bourdieu distinguishes logical logic from practical logic. By calling them both "logics," he connects as well as distinguishes them. Ritual, it seems, is the epitome of practical logic: "Rites, even more than most practices, might almost be designed to demonstrate the fallacy of seeking to contain in concepts a logic that is made to do without concepts."[413] Bourdieu thinks that when we either explain or interpret rituals, we are making them say what, for a practitioner, goes, or should go, without saying.

> If ritual practices and representations are practically coherent, this is because they arise from the combinatorial functioning of a small number of generative schemes that are linked by relations of practical substitutability, that is, capable of producing results that are equivalent in terms of the "logical" requirements of practice. This systematicity remains loose and approximate because the schemes can receive the quasi-universal application they are given only in so far as they function in
> p. 246 the practical ↳ state, below the level of explicit statement and therefore outside the control of logic, and in relation to practical purposes which require of them and give them a necessity which is not that of logic.[414]

According to Bourdieu, although rituals are practiced, they are not practical, and although they are outside the control of logic, they have their logic. Notice how Bourdieu implies that he himself grasps this logic. But if he can understand this hidden logic, who is to say that practitioners can't? If nothing else, they can read Bourdieu. Although I agree with Bourdieu in many ways, there is, I think, a fundamental difference between habituation and ritualization. Habituation is a sociobiological process that begins at, or even before, birth and is carried out automatically, much as one breathes. Habituation happens. Ritual, on the other hand, happens deliberately, at least partly by design. Someone or, more typically, some group constructs it, even if they later forget or obscure this fact. Across time, people may habituate their participation and understanding of their own rituals, just as most of us do in other activities, but that habituation does not alter the fact that, however natural a ritual is supposed to feel, it is not a natural event or cultural inevitability; it is an imaginative human creation. And this fact can in many instances be recollected. So I do not agree that "practice excludes attention to itself."[415] Certain practitioners may wish to inhibit reflection or quell criticism of their rituals, but, to reify momentarily in Bourdovian fashion, we could say that rituals themselves sometimes announce their own fictionality in the same moment that they attempt to hide it.

Now that several terms are flying through the air, it would help to summarize and distinguish among several "action" words (list 11) in the ritual studies glossary.

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List 11. Action Words

- event: occurrence with a discernible beginning and ending
- motion: movement in or through space
- action: movement to which intention and/or meaning is attributed
- behavior: action regarded as an object of analysis
- performance: action insofar as it is either witnessed or fictive
- enactment: action insofar as it puts something into force, exerts influence, or has effect beyond itself
- practice: actions engraining, or designed to engrain, persistent attitudes or skills
- witnessing: the action of supportive watching and listening
- spectating: the action of watching while minimizing or eliminating participation
- receptivity: the action of "taking in"
- avoidance: the action of "not doing"

The surface of a ritual consists of bodies in motion during events bounded with discernible beginnings and
p. 247 endings. When scholars study a ritual, they necessarily ↳ objectify it as behavior. However, knowing that ritual bodies are human, scholars typically attribute subjectivity, intention, or meaning to them. Ritual actions are not only overly active but also receptive, including actions such as witnessing or avoidance that may look on the surface like inaction. Rituals are practices insofar as they engrain persistent attitudes; performances insofar as they are either witnessed or framed as fictive; and enactments insofar as they exercise force beyond their own boundaries.

Whether we consider sensing (seeing, hearing, smelling, and so on) kinds of action or think of "the senses" as attributes of ritual actors is not very important, but the choice becomes strategic if your decision brings with it methodological choices. Studying people's ways of, say, making sounds and responding to them, you might proceed ethnomusicologically. Or, studying their ways of moving, you might proceed ethnochoreologically. In either case you would start from actual performances of singing and hearing singing, of dancing and witnessing dance.

Alternatively, informed by a psychology of the senses, we might prefer to start with ritual actors themselves. A thorough study of ritual actors would include their senses, just as a full study of ritual action would treat the actions of seeing, hearing, touching, smelling, and tasting. However we approach the task, theorizing about ritual should attend to the way rituals mobilize and perform the senses. All human experience is mediated by the senses, even though there are debates about how many there are; proprioception, your kinesthetic sense, is a recent addition to the conventional five. Powerful ritual experiences heighten the senses' interactions with one another, sometimes resulting in synesthesia, a cross-tabulating of the senses that can be either integrative or disorienting.

An essential analytical move in the study of a ritual is querying its sensorium mobilization: Which senses do its performers heighten? Dampen? Ignore? How does a ritual transpose sensory data from one channel of sensory data to another? How are the ritual's visual practices integrated with its auditory ones? How is smell echoed or denied by taste? Are a ritual's kinesthetic practices consistent or inconsistent with its oral claims?

Although Judaism, Christianity, and Islam have periodically railed against the senses, all three have ritually utilized them, even exploited them. These traditions share a common veneration of audition, especially the

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word—spoken, heard, and written—thus of books containing inspired words. Reading or listening to them is a ceremonial demonstration of faith. Some segments of these religions also value vision and in fact treat deeply revelatory religious experiences as "visions." Other segments of these religious traditions are suspicious of things seen, shown, touched, and venerated. This suspicion has set loose periodic waves of iconoclasm, critiques and attacks on visual images, especially anthropomorphic ones set up as visual representations of the divine.

Although vision and audition have dominated the three multinational monotheisms, the other senses—
p. 248 gestation (taste), olfaction (smell), and tactioception ↳ (touch)—have played persistent but secondary roles. Gustatory sensations have been enhanced by eating rituals and dietary restrictions. Kinesthetic and tactile senses have been aroused on pilgrimages walked by participants hoping to touch some sacred object or edifice.

Once you lift out a ritual element for analysis, students of ritual begin to recognize what we have left out. If I were to return to Santa Fe, I would take a much less frontal view. The actions shown in my videos are almost all big and public, with brief sideways glances at ordinary participants doing ordinary things like eating. I would, for instance, like to follow preparatory actions, playing them off one another by asking whether there is a consistent relationship between prep time and the importance of the performances. Does a mother dressing her son for a Zozobra rehearsal spend more or less time than the archbishop preparing his sermon for delivery at Rosario Chapel? Is the ratio direct or inverse? How does backstage bell ringing in the cathedral compare with front-stage song leading? Both are considered facilitating actions, but is one valued more than the other?

Ritual Actors

Students of ritual aspire to study whole persons in their relevant contexts. But we can't get at a whole person any more than we can experience a whole fiesta. Knowing this limitation, we have to begin somewhere: with the semblance of a body, regardless of what one makes of the idea of the body or what contexts one aspires to paint. Maybe people have auras or souls, maybe not, but most of us cannot see, much less video them. Maybe bodies don't ultimately matter, but bodies are what researchers have to work with and work on. Both constrained and empowered by bodies—ours as well as theirs—we students of ritual train our eyes, thus the crosshairs of our cameras, on bodies. Bodies in motion trigger the brain. Animals that we are, we're hardwired to notice other bodies in motion. They could be friends; they could be foes. When a body ceases moving, humans notice the stillness. Is he dead? Does she see something I don't?

With a camera we can document an action, but only by simultaneously documenting an actor, so it might seem pointless to distinguish ritual actors from ritual actions. For some analytical purposes, we may not need to do so, but in most ritual circumstances, as in most theatrical ones, roles can stand apart from the people who enact them. Ritual actors are not always the "authors" of their own actions; rather, they may be "echoing" or "quoting" in a way that resembles a stage actor's recitation of lines from a script. Although this disjunction between action and actor is not *the* distinguishing feature of ritual, it is widespread enough that we need to investigate the multiple ways in which actors identify or disindentify with their ritual roles.

This analytical separability of actors and actions is reinforced by the fact that roles often outlive persons.
p. 249 Ritualists become infirm or die, and some other qualified person ↳ steps into their role. On the one hand, if scholars were to make ritual actors the sole focus of research, the risk would be that of reducing rituals to the biographies or psychologies of participants, thereby producing ethnographic life history rather than ritual studies. On the other, if scholars were to focus exclusively on ritual actions, ignoring the people who enact them, these people would likely resist. Maybe ritualists can't always explain their rituals articulately. Even so, we query them, because they are persons who inhabit their rituals. We would not enter a home without paying respects, nor should we enter a ritual without inquiring after those who enact it. However much ritual behavior interests us, we cannot study only it, at least not during fieldwork.

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No element of ritual is intelligible as a hermetically sealed unit. Ritualists not only perform their actions (as subjects); they are also constituted by these actions (as objects).[416] Likewise, ritual actions, even if carefully observed and fully described, do not speak for themselves. An action's meanings are modified not only by the actions that precede and follow it but also by the intentions of those performing it, even if their intention is to have no intention of their own. Consequently, observing actions quickly leads to interviewing participants, who not only enact gestures and assume postures but also interpret and evaluate rituals. Since intentions are not directly accessible, researchers ask questions: What does that gesture mean? Why did you say that? And even after participants reply, interpreters continue to puzzle: How do words *about* rituals function? How do they differ from words *in* rituals? Are verbalized meanings the only kind? What are the other kinds? What are the implied (as distinct from the overtly stated ones) meanings?

Ritual actors, unlike stage actors, are not supposed to be pretending (although they may in fact be). Although they may be performing, because they are aware of being observed, they are also supposed to enact something as agents who accomplish something. Ritual agents are also social persons, not merely agents or performers, so usually they interact; they do not act alone. They do what they do among and with other people. Although ritualists typically act in groups, they also sometimes act as individuals. Since no one escapes socialization and enculturation, even solitary ritual actors interact, because others inhabit their brains and bodies, if not genetically then culturally. Since all human actors are affiliated—whether marginally or centrally, whether by choice or dint of birth—no ritual actor stands outside of gender, race, class, age, or the myriad other means of social classification. However vigorously participants may wish or claim that ritual participation vitiates the markers of such distinctions, ritual studies researchers take note of them. Who is acting in concert with whom? Who is avoiding whom? Such questions are keys to understanding the power of ritual.

Ritualists are not only performers acting among or in front of others; they accomplish things. An agent is one who acts—sometimes strategically, sometimes naively—to effect or inhibit change. Because everyone, even the most passive participant, exercises some kind of agency, all participants are doers, even if they do nothing more than show up or stay away. Some actors are leaders; others are ↳ followers. Still others both lead and follow. It is not uncommon for participants to shift between leading and following. Ritual roles can be few or many, and they can be hierarchically arranged, as if on a ladder, or democratically flattened, as if on an even plane. Some roles, usually the most important ones, have formal names; others are generic, without proper title. As well, there may be behind-the-scenes actors whose activities have an impact on actions in central ritual spaces. Drummers, like custodians, may be scarcely visible, considered outside the ritual, but they may also be paid and regarded as utterly essential to the ritual, because they provide the rhythmic ground on which ritual participants walk.

p. 250

The video “Caribbean Carnival: Animating Bacchanal” tracks Benjamin Alunyo, a photographer, during a massive, highly photogenic festival.[417] Deciding which is the primary action in the festival—costuming, dancing, or being photographed—would be difficult. On the one hand, Alunyo is an outsider to the action; his act of picture taking is parasitic upon the insider action of dancing in costume. However, if you watch him closely, you'll notice that he moves into a group and animates it. He doesn't just shoot what's there. He's helping making the event what it is. More shy with my camera and worrying about invading people's privacy, I got some quizzical looks. After following Alunyo for a while, I figured out why. I wasn't doing my part. Dancers were inviting my camera's attention, posing for it, competing for photographic attention. They weren't only enacting their Caribbean-Canadian cultures, thereby carving out cultural space in Toronto; they were performing those cultures, showing and showing off for spectators with and without cameras. On the one hand, you could say that photographers like Alunyo were objectifying the dancers. On the other, you could say that he was responding to their agency.

Don't decide too soon who or what can be an agent. The range, as described by participants, is considerable, and it includes not only individuals, corporate entities, organizations, and collectives but also deities, the dead, animals, and spirits. Often it helps to ask where such actors and actions are located. Do they show up in the

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here and now in ritual, or are they confined to myth and religious talk? Theorists tend not to mobilize supernatural agents for explanatory purposes, but instead cast abstractions—Culture, Society, the Market—as agents. The danger is less in the reifying than in not recognizing what you are doing.

It is widely assumed among scholars who study ritual that the "proper" or "real" ritual agent is the collective, the so-called corporate body, excluding individuals, gods, places, and objects. If you define ritual as collective effervescence, then of course individuals do not act ritually. But the fact is that individuals do things in closets and forests that they call ritual. You can ignore such activity as outside the purview of your definition of ritual, as socially insignificant or deluded, but you are also sidestepping the basic question: How shall we understand ritual-like activities in closets or forests, regardless of what we or they call them? And how shall we handle participants' attribution of agency to gods and objects and places? My preference is to leave the matter as a set
p. 251 of open questions for investigation: Who do ↳ participants say is acting here? Whom do we observe acting? How do they know who or what is acting? How do we know? Having to respond to such questions might precipitate a dialogue or debate between researchers and the researched.

Even if there is disagreement over supernatural agency, and even if practitioners supernaturalize their rituals, they are human social events carried out by human agents. However much practitioners may model their actions after nonhuman agents, human actors are a prerequisite. No people, no ritual, no ritual studies. Maybe the gods ritualize in transcendent realms, but if they do, our cameras cannot go there. The focus of ritual studies research on human agency is practical and provisional, not ontological or absolute.

As with studying ritual action, studying ritual actors can become theoretically dense, because many roles (list 12) and several distinctions come into play.

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List 12. Ritual Roles

- person: human being in the fullest, most complex sense
- ritualist: ritual participant, ritual actor, ritual insider, a person in ritual circumstances
- ritual leader: primary ritual actor, front-stage ritual participant
- ritual follower: secondary ritual actor, backstage ritual participant
- ritual facilitator, facilitating agent: one who helps make the ritual possible
- ritual witness: a participant who observes and whose observation contributes to the action
- ritual agent: any ritual actor who acts, influences, or exercises power
- collective ritual agent: a group acting in concert
- nonhuman ritual agent: e.g., gods, spirits, animals, the deceased as ritual actors; also places or objects as ritual actors
- participant-observer: one who studies ritual by participating as well as observing, often a scholar
- ritual studies scholar: student of ritual, a person who studies ritual academically
- observing participant: participant who assumes an observer's role and whose observation is intrinsic to the action
- spectator: one whose watching or listening is extrinsic to the action, usually an outsider, e.g., a tourist
- ritual interpreter
  - indigenous interpreter: an insider who offers exegesis of a ritual
  - outside interpreter: an observer who offers exegesis of a ritual
  - ritual critic: an evaluative interpreter, sometimes indigenous, sometimes an outsider

I have opted for ordinary English terms. There may, of course, be other roles and other ways to name them. The
p. 252 point is to suggest casting a wide net, noticing not ↳ only front-and-center ritual leaders but also those who facilitate or witness, even those who appear to be doing nothing.

During fieldwork it is rude if not imperialistic to reduce people to their roles. In theorizing, however, scholars usually study roles even though we observe participants outside ritual settings to remind ourselves of their personhood. As observers we may participate, just as participants themselves may observe. Each party has its perspective. Expressed, these perspectives become interpretations. Although one or the other kind of interpretation may be privileged, and although one interpretation may *in fact* be better than another, neither is *in principle* superior to the other.

Role construction, formation, and maintenance are among the functions of ritual, so studying ritual actors requires an inquiry into identity. Rituals can be formative, exerting pressure on participants' sense of themselves. In ritual, you become, one might say, more than who you normally are. Either that, or you become more yourself than you are without the power of ritual; you enter a ritual arena in order to become other. You feel fully seen, accepted, and understood in a ritual. Alternatively, you are immersed, not seen at all. Maybe you enter a ritual's precincts flamboyantly arrayed or spiritually naked. Perhaps you become a spirit; perhaps you become "one of us." You are connected, let us say, not only with some others but also with *the* others who count,

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perhaps with Otherness itself. In ritual whatever was outside the self is now inside the self. Whatever was split off is now interlaced and interconnected. Alternatively, while ritualizing, you are supremely alone. There is only one; you contain all; all contains you. Any way you put it, many ritual actors aspire to consolidate or transform. However participants express it—and there are a myriad ways—in ritual something is supposed to happen to their identity. It is confirmed, established, transformed, transposed, transmogrified, transcended. What's the right word? If something doesn't happen, well, there are several possibilities. The ritual didn't work; the ritual actor wasn't prepared. His or her expectations were wrong. The performance was flawed. Failing an identity transformation or confirmation, a ritual actor has alternatives. He or she can pretend, not worry about it, redo the whole thing, or blame the ritual. Still, the question remains for both insiders and outsiders: Who do ritualists become by enacting rituals? Ritualists know, or at least they should know. And scholars know, or at least wish they knew. How do we students of ritual access identity and its transformation? In many ways, but most immediately by examining talk and comportment: How do ritual agents embody themselves? How do they enact others? How do they manage their identities? Which self is displayed, and which hidden? What names and roles do ritualists claim? What do they understand a person, especially a ritualizing one, to be? Of what does a ritual agent consist—body? soul? spirit? atman? *jiva*?

A major problem in conceptualizing ritual actors is that the scholarship has been strongly biased in favor of adult male ritual leaders, thereby sidelining others. Focused on ritual leaders, scholars have paid less attention
p. 253 to ritual followers, females, LGBT people, people with disabilities, children, and the elderly (except in ↳ cultures where they have an elevated status as "elders"). Feminist and queer scholars have begun the work of rectification, but the entrenchment is deep.[418] There is no similar movement to understand the ritual sensibilities of children. With the exception of Erik Erikson and the few scholars who have built on his research, the phenomenon of ritual development and age-specific ritual competence has been severely understudied (see Appendix 5: Stages of Ritual Development). It is unproductive, if not irresponsible, to consider persons in general or ritual actors more specifically without also taking into account kinds of people and their stages in life. For this reason the study of ritual actors necessarily leads to the study of ritual groups, especially those disadvantaged by ritual studies itself.

Along with the question, *who* is acting in this ritual, is *whether* this acting constitutes ritual? It is not always easy to know when people are engaging in a ritual act. See that woman sitting on a bench, head down. Is that sleeping or praying? We need more information. Is she whispering words? If so, maybe that's a prayer. But what if she is only imagining words? If the words are only in the head or heart, is that ritual? Should we call it something else if there are no obvious actions—no bowed head, no moving lips? Ritual can transpire by subtracting from, rather than adding to, ordinary action. A ritual can consist of the cessation of action, of, for example, becoming still and quiet. But what if there is no telltale gross motor behavior? What if a person is just walking down a road, but inside, in the imagination or heart, she is entertaining a practiced sequence of colors or images? Is that ritual action?

My first inclination is to say no, but that's probably because I am a Westerner conditioned to distinguish between bodies and something else (minds, souls, spirits ...). So let's put it another way: If ritual action is completely interiorized, we must look for ways of studying it other than participant observation. Even though we can study brain activity, we cannot yet monitor internalized ritual activity. So, rather than say that interior ritual is not ritual, let's more modestly admit that there are not yet good methods for studying such rituals.

We who study ritual remind ourselves repeatedly that, although we can observe, document, and infer, we do not have direct access to everything. Some facet is always turned away from view, like the dark side of the moon. No one can peer into the head of another, spying the mind or heart, seeing how that person understands the world. So, although ritual studies starts with the obvious, moving bodies and the exterior surfaces of things, it is necessary to posit a human interiority as well, because people don't say everything they think or express everything they feel. Whether we speak of attitudes, beliefs, or values, we Westernized academics tend to

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imagine such things as metaphorically interior to actors. One can imagine them otherwise, for instance, as the products of institutions.

That said, attitudes are embodied, therefore displayed if we have eyes to see and ears to hear, so the student of ritual tries to infer them from words and actions.[419] Attitudes are not mere habits, and they are conditioned by
p. 254 both emotions and beliefs. Attitudes condense values, beliefs, worldviews, images, and feelings into ↳ predispositions to act.[420] Attitudes are partly revealed, partly hidden. A sailboat's attitude is its tilt, or cant, in response to the wind. It is visible even though the wind is not. Displays are imperfect, and so are our perceptions and interpretations of them, so what we conclude about attitudes is partly inference and partly conjecture.

There is no single, definitive ritual attitude, although some attitudes are probably more recurrent than others. Ritual is associated with a wide range of attitudes, and some of them seem opposite, or contradictory. On the one hand, ritual actions can be done in a perfunctory manner without apparent enthusiasm or commitment; those engaged in it seem disengaged, their commitment superficial or apathetic. On the other hand, rituals are performed with either concentrated attentiveness or mindfulness to detail; those engaged in them are sure they are supremely important, more life-giving than other life-enhancing activities such as working or cooking food. In meditation rituals, the attitudinal aspiration is attentive clarity. Although attention may be either focused or diffuse, no particular emotion is required. Meditating, one may feel happy or sad, indifferent or ecstatic, but fluctuations of thoughts and emotions are attended to with detachment rather than indulgence. By contrast, celebrations and festivals cultivate expansive sociability, and funerals typically, but by no means exclusively, expect somber attitudes.

In studying ritual actors it is crucial to distinguish espoused beliefs, values, and attitudes from implied ones. Espoused ones are those people say they hold or consciously display. They may offer words as exegesis of their actions when queried by others, and they may, in fact, hold the beliefs expressed in those words, but they may, in fact, not. Among humans, even those aspiring to tell the truth, there is an imperfect fit between what we say and what we do. We can lie either verbally or gesturally, we can be self-deceived, or we can be ignorant. Since perfect self-knowledge is unlikely, astute observers try to infer the values, attitudes, and beliefs that participants "give off" (as distinct from those they willingly display). And, make no mistake about it, we observers or theorists are just as subject to these distortions as participants are.

People engaged in ritual acts may not necessarily believe what they say they do, and they may not believe the same things that other people beside them believe. Collective ritual engagement may seem to imply shared assumptions and values, but a scholar has to discern, rather than assume, which are shared and which are not. Scholars may begin by inquiring after those held in common, but they ought not to stop there. Since all social configurations include subgroups and divisions, there are likely corresponding differences not only of opinion but also of core beliefs and formative attitudes. Perhaps we can posit a loose link between ritual actions and ritual beliefs, but we cannot infer belief from action or predict action from belief.

Human interiority—the zone where beliefs, values, and attitudes are cached—is, in effect, an offstage area. To put it another way, ritual action can serve as a mask, a display calling attention to itself and away from one's interiority. I can be performing one thing while thinking or feeling quite another. Dissembling is a fact of all
p. 255 life, not ↳ only ritual life. Since impression management is so rife in ritual circumstances, the dissonance between attitude and performance can be particularly intense. Because rituals are sometimes occasions during which collectively held beliefs, values, and attitudes are powerfully displayed, sincerely held personal beliefs, values, and attitudes may be the *least* visible during them. Whether and how beliefs and worldviews are displayed or masked during a ritual is a question that can only be answered in specific cases, not in general. Because dissonance between saying and doing is common among humans, it is worth posing dramatistic questions about ritual acts: Who is acting how in front of whom? Who benefits from being perceived in what ways? What benefits are gained from being perceived to hold certain attitudes, values, and beliefs?

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For ritual studies the center of observation may be a group of participants enacting a ritual, but there is a circumference as well as an inferred interiority. People exit their rituals, sometimes taking leave of their ritual personas. People are not always ritual actors. People's lives go on, and we need to know how their extraritualistic lives interface with their ritual activities. How do they make the transition? Do they change clothes? Who are they when they leave? When a ritual concludes and its participants depart, does a behavioral curtain drop? Do the ritual actors continue to perform? Are their quotidian postures and gestures ritually inflected? Do participants bring stuff home? Do they sing songs they heard? Are their values changed or reconfirmed? Who are these people when they are enacting rituals, and who are they when they are not? The only way to answer such question is by tracking extraritualistic behavior.

David Trujillo played General Diego de Vargas in 2007. Given more time I would have tracked him with a camera onstage and off, as he interacted with his *cuadrilla*, schoolkids, and city and church authorities. What does he say? Avoid saying? What signals does his body language emit? When, where, and why does he switch from being David to being de Vargas? What are his other roles? During his knighting he becomes, with some apparent resistance, the son of his mother, who insists on repeatedly straightening his cape. How does he verbalize these shifts as he sees them played back on video? Who or what, I would ask, acts through you? Besides yourself, whom else do you embody? Your ancestors? God? De Vargas? And how long do they stay with or in you?

To what extent is Trujillo acting as an individual and to what extent, as a representative of an age cohort, organization, ethnic group, religious group? What does he claim are his most compelling values and beliefs? I would ask his friends, "What values and beliefs does David's life imply?" I would elicit from David memories about ordinary things: What does he recall from his stroll through the plaza this morning? Does he talk about smells and tastes or sounds and sights? Does he feel his boots thudding on the sidewalk? I would pose similar questions about other venues: church, stage, workplace. Because David speaks so generically in *Behind the*
p. 256 *Scenes of the Santa Fe Fiesta*, I would ask him to talk specifically about the Entrada he ↳ has just performed by showing him footage and asking him to stop it and comment on it as often as he wished. Tracking him in and out of his fiesta role, I would be in a better position to paint a portrait of David as a ritual actor.

Ritual Places

Ritual fantasies and ritual theories can happen anywhere; ritual events, only in a place. Whether or not ritual actors value their locations, most rituals are sited, sometimes in one place, sometimes in several. Like every other human activity, ritual activity arises from physically embodied, geographically situated, socially embedded people. Some participants will tell you otherwise, insisting that God is universal, that the body is not real, or that their rituals transcend the mundane. In ritual, as in myth, participants may tell you they are transported to other times and places, but they do so from here and now. They may be right, or they may be wrong, but if you want to study ritual, you cannot afford to ignore the spatial rootedness of human life.

Ritual space is often conceptualized on an either/or model: architectural/natural; inside/outside; central/peripheral; static/mobile; permanent/temporary; sacred/nonsacred; high/low; near/far; public/private; paid for/free; space (abstract, empty) / place (specific, geographical); set (constructed) / setting (given, there). Actual human activity often happens between, not at the extreme ends of, such oppositional polarities. Some places are less easily polarized: ecological niches, transitional zones, dividers, boundaries, performance spaces, memorials, commemorative places, places close to something else such as water, shrines, or disaster sites.

It is easier to conceptualize ritual space if the example is a mosque or megachurch building, but even when there is no built edifice with walls separating inside from out, a boundary is often implied by ritual actions, generating a center and circumference, both of which can fluctuate, the center receding and advancing or momentarily disappearing altogether as subgroups disperse and recongeal. Even so, one can usually trace the

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spatial patterns implied by ritually choreographed movements. Mapping them is fundamental to the study of ritual space.

The permanent/temporary distinction is worth pondering, because it opens up the question “When is a ritual space a ritual space?” A cemetery remains a ritual space even when no burial or ash-scattering is going on, but after the Woodstock Festival of 1969 Max Yasgur's field became what it was before this era-defining festival. After Peter Schumann's annual Domestic Resurrection Circus in Glover, Vermont, the performance grounds revert to the farmer from whom they are rented so the crops and weeds can resume their ordinary lives. These spaces are made ritual spaces by the actions occurring in them. Once the actions stop, the spaces are no longer ritualistic.

p. 257 Ritual space is any place where a ritual occurs, but as a definition, this way of putting it is not only minimal but also circular, ignoring the fact that specific places matter enormously for some rituals. If these rituals do not happen in the right place or facing the proper direction, they lose force. For other rituals, place is incidental, hardly mattering at all. The actions matter, but their location is irrelevant. So even though rituals happen in places, making them ritual spaces, not all ritual spaces are sacred spaces, and not all sacred spaces are permanently so. The sense of a place can change, and a single person can hold conflicting attitudes toward a place.

In documenting the deconsecration of a rural Canadian United Church in southern Ontario, my colleague Barry Stephenson and I initiated a place-focused research project. Its first result was an online album of still photographs, which seemed appropriate to a building. Church members responded by saying the pictures made them see things they had overlooked or never even seen, because they were too familiar with the building, a rare round church. They had only come to appreciate the place, they said, when outsiders showed up taking pictures and considering the fate of the place. We were gratified but soon realized that by studying only the building we would be replicating what was already going on: the severing of the people from the place. So to put people and place together, we turned to video.[421] One of the videos, “The Deconsecration of a Canadian Church,” weaves the liturgy of deconsecration together with reflections and memories of church members, most of whom are mourning the loss of their church even as they try to celebrate its life and comprehend the demographic shifts that are destroying many other rural churches in Ontario.[422] On the one hand, since they are Protestants, the place shouldn’t matter, because ideally, theologically, the church consists of people, not buildings. Referring to another church that died while she was a member, Mary Attridge, the oldest member of the congregation, declares, “It was just bricks and mortar” (19:54ff.). However, she adds, “I have a brick from that building.” The building doesn’t matter; the building does matter. Weeping, Bonnie Fenton, another member insists, “It's not just a building.” Later she calls the building their church “home.” Her husband, a farmer who is helping to lead the deconsecration service, is fighting back tears, because the place matters. Losing the place as a church, he feels he has failed his ancestors. These conflicting sentiments are played out not only between people but within individuals. The dissonant voices are lifted out and replayed side by side near the end of the film (31:25ff.). Another video, “Highgate United,” picks up where the first one leaves off.[423] The church is now becoming the Mary Webb Centre for culture and arts.[424] While some former members are still insisting, “It will always be a church,” others seem more content to let it be a fabulous-looking place with great acoustics.

The sense of a place can change whether or not people want it to change, and place matters even to people who adhere to creeds that say it doesn’t. Even if rituals are said to happen in transcendent space, they necessarily
p. 258 happen in a location. Consequently, rituals also orient even if that is not their primary intention. ↳
Orienteering is the science and art of finding one's way, usually with map and compass, sometimes with only stars and the sun. Ritual is a means of being oriented in the cosmos, and a cosmos is the world as ritually and mythically constituted. Even an initiation rite, containing phases of deliberate disorientation, aims to orient participants so they know how to find their way as adults in their culture's world. When one's world is ritually

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oriented, space is no longer abstract, and one place may not be as good or powerful as another. Ritually considered, some places are more generative than others. To go them is orienting, therefore life-giving.

Most of us intuitively understand that a synagogue, mosque, or cathedral is in some sense sacred regardless of how Judaism, Islam, and Christianity theologically conceptualize space. If nothing else, such places are sacralized behaviorally. People comport themselves differently in them as they move from outside to inside or from front to back. As spaces become sacred they also become qualitative, not merely quantitative and geometric but also value-laden.

People and things occupy positions relative to one another. Some are above; some below. Some are to the left, others to the right. These positions matter: The sun rises in the East; from it Christians expect the resurrection to come. If you are a Muslim in the West, the Kaaba stone, located in Mecca, is symbolically east. Sometimes in mosques there is an arrow pointing out the *qibla*, the direction of prayer. Literally, geographically, from where I live Mecca is 53.77 degrees north, so "northeast" is a more accurate description of the proper orientation for prayer.[425]

Righteousness is to your right. Upward is onward, therefore better. In ritual, prepositions are no longer "mere"; they have consequences. Location in architectural or geographical space has symbolic valence. To be down is to submit to a lower status, to show humility or respect. To be up is to be venerated as important. Literal positions are metaphoric insofar as they stand for social positions. Sheep on the right and goats on the left are not merely two separate but equal lines. Those on the one side will bask in eternal sunlight and walk streets of gold (with green pastures on both sides and a fish fry at the end).[426] Those on the other will go to hell and suffer eternal torture.

"Space speaks."[427] It has meaning. Sometimes people can articulate this meaning in words; sometimes the meaning has to be inferred from their actions. No one has to tell you that it is rude to converse while turning your back to listeners or standing on a chair and looking downward at them. However, a Masonic friend might have to instruct you that the checkerboard floor on which you are standing symbolizes life, checkered as it is with good and evil. Space sometimes speaks more clearly to those who have ears trained to hear what it says.

In some cultures, spaces not only mean; they also act. Not merely containing or framing actions, a sacred place exerts force, becoming an agent on par with, or even greater than, a ritual leader. The mountains and rivers were here before we mere mortals strolled the face of the earth. Those places—beings, actually—acted, thereby
p. 259 facilitating the emergence of creatures like us.[428] So space is not necessarily ↳ passive, the spectator or butt of human design. Sometimes it can be a lead actor, to whom (yes, whom) human actions are but a response. Human ritual activity is secondary, even a little pretentious.

Because a ritual is necessarily spatialized, it implies an ecology, a mode of engaging its locale and the world. However, ecologically attuned practice doesn't necessarily follow from this fact. A ritual conditions its practitioners to ignore or attend to the place they inhabit, to treat it as theirs, or themselves as belonging to it. Ritualists, like producers and consumers, can minimize or tune out the environments in which they conduct their business. Even though rituals are necessarily on the planet, they do not necessarily attune participants to it. Rituals can insulate practitioners from the ground they walk and the air they breathe. In the 1950s, rituals of consumption taught us it was okay to drive blithely down highways tossing candy wrappers out car windows.[429]

Rituals operate in environments that are simultaneously biological, geographical, social, political, historical, and cultural.[430] A ritual's environment is the totality of whatever surrounds it and interacts with it. The traffic is two-way, although not necessarily equal. Participants walk into ritual precincts and then walk out, carrying with them in both directions ideas, feelings, images, and predispositions to act (or not). Some rituals are designed to minimize this traffic, others to maximize it. In either case, to study a ritual by whittling away its contexts without ever reconstructing them is to make a serious mistake. Environments suffuse rituals, and

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rituals touch or even create environments. Although condensed into events with beginnings and endings or ensconced in thick walls, rituals nevertheless leak, exerting influence and being influenced. Not only shaped, rituals shape environments, even after their enactments conclude. The words and songs may have evaporated, but the legs remember; so do the back and neck. Transposed into kinesthetic memories, rituals take up mental and social space. Because they are oriented (do it here, not there, please), they orient; by engaging in them, you learn the appropriate posture for navigating the world.

Rituals happen in *settings*, geographical environments that are "there," but they also happen on constructed *sets* used to frame them. The set of a ritual is an artifact, whereas its setting is more or less a given. Both are relative, of course, since there is no such thing as either an absolute given or construction out of nothing. As a given, a ritual environment precedes and exceeds the ritual itself; it is a force field encircling a ritual, those who enact it, and even those who study it. As an artifact, a ritual set is built of all sorts of things, some of it tangible, some of it conceptual, thereby transforming the given into the made-over. Scholars too construct—actually, reconstruct—rituals by setting them in a *context*, which is itself constructed out of scenes selected from a ritual's actual environment. Just as ritualists select actions for rituals, so authors construct ritual descriptions by hunting for causes that determine their shape, looking for their consequences, and mapping their connections and disconnections with the surrounding environment.

p. 260 Every scholarly query requires an excision of some part of a ritual's actual environment as the relevant context for interpreting or explaining that ritual. The interpretively reconstructed environment never equals the actual environment. To study a ritual by setting it in a selected context, then, is to craft a *frame*. As in matting and framing a picture, you can use contrasting or complementary colors, select heavy or light stock. The frame can be thin and wiry, or it can be heavy, grabbing more attention than the picture itself. Scholars may claim their frames are scientifically constructed, but frames are also determined by aesthetic considerations. Is the boundary of a studied ritual imagined as permeable impermeable? To what extent does the ritual allow itself to be changed by permeation? What things are filtered out? What passes through? In which direction? In? Out? Both ways? How densely bounded is this ritual? Who frames it this way? Participants? Select groups of participants? Scholars?

Students of ritual should notice not only the actual spaces of a ritual but also the spatial metaphors used by ritual actors and scholars of ritual. Speaking of cultural and mental "space" is widespread. Container metaphors are beguiling and insidious; we quickly lose track of them, and they readily take over. So ritual studies scholars should notice when people shift from speaking of bodily or geographical space to using spatial metaphors in reference to nonspatial things. Posing the right questions can help us keep track of them: For participants, what is literally central and peripheral? What is metaphorically central and peripheral? Who sits or stands above and below whom? Who is socially higher and lower? Where are the physical boundaries of their rituals? What are the theological or mythological boundaries? Which way is inside, and which way is outside? Who is an insider, and who is an outsider? By posing such questions we are less likely to erase the difference between physical and metaphoric space.

Religious studies scholar Jonathan Z. Smith proposes a spatialized theory of ritual.[431] Although both spatial and "actional" rhetoric appear in *To Take Place*, spatial metaphors assume a pronounced theoretical ascendancy. Smith makes statements that sound like they could support an action theory of ritual: for example, "Ritual is, first and foremost, a mode of paying attention." However, these statements are often displaced by a spatial reductionism evident, for instance, in the chapter's epigraph, "Nothing shall have taken place but place,"[432] and in repeated assertions such as "Sacrality is, above all, a category of emplacement."[433] Thus, the "where" of ritual becomes theoretically more important than the "how" of it.

Smith speaks of "place" rather than "sacred space" to differentiate himself rhetorically from phenomenologists such as Mircea Eliade and to evoke the more specifically social meanings of "place." Nevertheless, spatiality and placement remain determinative of Smith's conception of ritual. It is treated not simply as one dimension of

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ritual but as the fundamental one. For him, ritual action does not make space sacred; rather, placement renders actions sacred. Whereas Eliade construes the center as sacred to religion, thus to his theory of religion, Smith renders placement central, thus privileged, to his theory of ritual.

p. 261 Essential to maintaining the primacy of place in Smith's theory of ritual is his deployment of the notion in both a literal and a metaphoric fashion. Sometimes his topic is an actual geographical place—Jerusalem, for instance—but often it is placement, that is, mental schemes and social classifications. Too often he slips between one usage and the other, making the shift without calling attention to it.[434]

In *To Take Place* temple rites ground Smith's generalizations about ritual. He construes temple ritual as "exemplary of ritual itself."[435] He argues that within the temple, "all was system from which nothing could distract."[436] For Smith, the temple was, metaphorically speaking, a map. In effect, he implies that there is a process whereby geographical sacred places give rise to nonspatialized modes of emplacement, that is, to intellectual systems. He argues that places facilitate a "prescission," an abstraction, from place while at the same time maintaining the centrality of place. He goes even further, claiming that there is no rift between the literal or geographical level and the conceptual or metaphoric one: "There is no break with the dynamics of ritual itself."[437]

My view is that there *is* a break and that interpreters, not places, make the move from geography to mental classification. Smith implies the existence of a smooth and necessary connection between intellectual and social order, on the one hand, and ritual, on the other. However true such a claim may be of temple ritual, I see no reason to conclude that this connection is definitive of ritual everywhere or ritual in general.

For Smith, place is not only central; it is active. As he imagines it, a place is not a mere empty or passive receptacle.[438] It is not just the context or backdrop of action but rather a force that forms actions and actors. As Kenneth Burke might have put it, "Scene acts."[439] Smith rejects performance theory in favor of a spatial theory, but he does so by casting place as lead actor. I have no doubt that in some ritual systems space is a primary ritual actor, but in others it is a mere backdrop.

In the Santa Fe Fiesta some of David Trujillo's actions and roles are space-specific. Playing de Vargas, he removes his helmet in the cathedral. Onstage he walks with theatrical pride. But how does he stroll Santa Fe's central plaza? How should he and other fiesta royalty walk and talk there? The plaza was there long before Trujillo walked it. On the one hand, it is spoken of as sacred space and as an apt symbol of Hispano displacement from Santa Fe, hence the importance of reclaiming it by performing the Entrada there.[440] On the other, the plaza is castigated as the center of an Adobe Disneyland, where Anglo "culture vultures" produce Santa Fe style for consumption by the rest of the world.[441] How does one behave in such a place? Everything depends on who "one" is. The place alone does not dictate behavior. The central plaza monument, which is an obelisk, was originally inscribed "To the heroes who have fallen in various battles with savage Indians in the Territory of New Mexico." Later, "savage" was removed. If you are a Pueblo, perhaps you keep your distance from the obelisk. If you are a tourist, you stroll around it, enjoying the space and thinking little about what is
p. 262 etched in or chiseled out of stone. If you are ↳ local and it is fiesta time, you avoid the plaza or you hang out there for the same reason: The area is jammed with people. Perhaps you go there to perform, but some performance spaces on the plaza are elevated, while others are not. The raised platforms command attention, while flat, grassy spaces merely invite it. It would not be easy to determine whether action or space dominates the plaza, because we would first have to answer tributary questions: Action by whom? In which subspace?

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Ritual Times

Imagining ritual as a spatial process, researchers search out its center and circumference. The ritual begins when, for example, participants walk through the door or enter the sanctuary, and it ends when people walk out the door or offsite. The ritual whole is everything between entering and exiting. Considering a ritual as a temporal process, students of ritual listen for its beginning and ending. A ritual begins, say, when someone says, "Let us begin," and it ends when a bell is struck with a certain recognizable rhythm. The ritual is what transpires in between. The beginning and ending of a ritual can also be less overt. It may begin when a single person is inspired to convene it. It may end when all feel that the work of the ritual is complete. Timing is not always determined by clocks and calendars.

The meaning of "ritual time" is not self-evident, because the phrase can refer to several different ways of reckoning a ritual's orchestration of time (see list 13).

List 13. Kinds of Ritual Time

- ritual duration: how long a ritual performance lasts
- ritual endurance: how long a ritual has survived historically
- ritual timing: when a ritual happens
- ritual phasing: the temporal patterning ("rhythm") of a ritual; a ritual's articulation of its beginning, middle, and end ("plot")
- ritual regularity: the evenness of intervals between enactments
- ritual frequency: how often a ritual happens
- ritual recursivity: a ritual's tendency to loop or turn back on itself
- ritual cross-temporality: time(s) to which a ritual refers or with which it aspires to connect

Just as rituals have spatial layouts, they have temporal qualities: a long ritual / a short ritual, ordinary time / holiday time. Rituals are temporally embedded, signifying multiple modes of measuring time: phases of the moon, seasons, holy days, auspicious times, definitive historical eras. In turn, rituals host temporal markers ranging from brief inhalations and exhalations to turns in cosmic cycles. The temporality of ritual is axiomatic for the same reason that its spatiality is: There is no escaping it.[442]

p. 263 That a ritual is an event seems so obvious as to be hardly worth mentioning, but one often hears "ritual" or "the ritual" used in ways that make a ritual seem like an object that transcends time and space. Regardless of which "other" kinds of time ritualists may claim to occupy, ritual studies scholars who expect to engage in public discourse necessarily inhabit the ordinary kind. Like games, plays, and concerts, rituals begin and end, and usually their beginnings and endings are marked—even if the marking is fuzzy—so people don't miss them: time to start; time to quit.

Like the performing arts, rituals "eventuate." They arise, persist for a while, and then disappear, perhaps leaving traces on the environment, in memory, or in a text. In Western proscenium theater, the curtains part, then people perform actions that other people witness. When the curtains close, the event terminates, and people go home. Whereas a work of plastic art persists even if it is on display this month but not next, a work of performing art disappears in the doing unless captured in some other medium, such as film or painting.

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A ritual's *duration* is the length of its performance, the time it takes to unfold as measured by whatever means: clock, bodily tiredness, position of the sun. The duration of rituals varies enormously. They can be as short as a handshake or as long as a life of monastic practice. The short ones can flit by unnoticed, perhaps even by those who perform them habitually, and in the long ones, surely there are flat moments when nothing ritually significant is going on.

How to determine a ritual's duration is not always evident. Suppose a cremation is followed a few days later by a funeral and interment, then by a memorial a year after, followed in a decade by the moving of flesh-free bones to a collective site. What is the duration of the ritual? Do the days and years between events count? Is this complex sequence best construed as one ritual comprised of several phases or as several rituals?

What do you do when some participants declare that, in truth, their liturgy never ends, because even when it is not going on down here on earth, it is going on up in heaven or in the recesses of the human heart? And what about preparation? When a rabbi prays as she studies the Torah in preparation for a sermon, does that count as part of the ritual? Does the memorial that takes place a year after a Jew's death count as part of the death ritual? And what about the fact that a ritual may branch out, hooking into another ritual, generating an entire ritual system? Where does a ritual begin and end? The question is neither rhetorical nor pedantic.

Just as a performance can be captured on film and then re-presented, so a ritual can disappear and reappear. Having done something they consider necessary and good, people can come back together and do similar (but never exactly the same) things as they did before in pretty much the same way. They can repeat the sequence over and over again. When a ritual repeats, thereby enduring, similarities may come to overshadow differences, making it alluring to think of ritual as if it were an architectural structure. This view is even more tempting
p. 264 when those similarities congeal into a script containing words and rubrics that prescribe or authorize ↳ actions. When a ritual goes from being a one-time event to being a repeated event underwritten by an authorized text, it appears to sit there the way a rock does. Consequently, two analogies, ritual-as-unchanging-structure and ritual-as-timeless-idea, are tempting theoretical models for scholars, since each seems to remove ritual from the ravages of time. With the emergence of repetition, persistence, and textuality, it is becomes likely that someone will transpose a ritual practice into an idea, something to think about, or, more complexly, to think with.

A ritual's *endurance* is how long the ritual lasts historically. Research on ritual endurance considers questions such as these: Did the ancestors perform this ritual? Where did it come from? What has been its life course? Did anyone invent it? Revise it? Buy the rights to it? Receive it as a gift? Resist changing it? In the course of a ritual's lifespan it can change shape, maybe even undergo a name change. Through time a ritual also probably changes functions, and participants change their intentions.

Because rituals emerge, they can also die. In fact, entire ritual systems have died out. Rituals and even ritual traditions have lifespans. Some persist for months, fewer for years or decades, fewer still for eons. No one practices ancient Greek or Roman ritual, not even Greeks or Romans. A few North American neopagans practice “ancient” Greek religion, but the performers are neither ancient nor Greek. Contemporary Egyptian rituals are for the most part Islamic, quite unlike ancient Egyptian rituals, which were, for part of their history, polytheistic rather than monotheistic. Where is ancient Egyptian pharaonic ritual now? Nowhere, although much of its residue—mummies, pyramids, inscriptions—is scattered throughout the world's museums. Echoes of ancient Egyptian rituals are found in Masonic and Mormon rituals, and symbols borrowed from the tradition appear on the backs of certain denominations of U.S. currency. The rituals are gone, but some of their elements endure.

When something endures, it can generate a history, written, oral, or mnemonic. A ritual's historicity has two facets. One is the history of the ritual itself: Is it known? Who tracks it and how—in writing or by memory? Are there conflicting versions? The second is its location in some broader (world, regional, national) history: At

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what points does the smaller history of the ritual itself break out into the larger cultural or political history? What was going on when the ritual emerged? How and how long did the ritual endure? How did it morph? How did it meet its demise?

Ritual *timing* denotes when rather than how long—the day, hour, week, month, or season of a ritual's occurrence. When are the ripe times? Sunrise? Sunset? The end of the year? The founder's birthday? The end or beginning of the week? The equinox or solstice? Who decides which are the auspicious or proper moments? By which group's calendar is the determination made? The same actions performed at sunrise and midnight impact bodies and crowds differently. The timing of some rituals is set; the timing of others varies. Easter is a "movable feast," its date varying from year to year. For complex historical and religious reasons, it is the Sunday
p. 265 following the full moon that comes on or after the spring equinox. In many ↳ instances the reasons for a ritual's timing are not obvious. Birth rituals may happen near the time of birth, or after a year, when survival is more likely, but people can choose to celebrate, say, their saint's day instead of their birthday. It might seem appropriate for coming-of-age rituals to coincide with biological puberty, but often they do not.

The timing of a ritual can serve different purposes. A ritual can be held at night because that's when people are not working or because darkness enhances mystery. Timing can also be motivated by conventional, accidental, or strategic considerations. An enthronement can be held on a holiday because that date is the legally mandated date for such events or because rulers know they can garner popular support if their coming to power is suffused with festivity.

November 17 is the anniversary of the Czech Republic's "Velvet Revolution" of 1989. On this day groups annually commemorate, celebrate, and compete. On the morning of November 17, 2012, a massive demonstration conducted by labor unions was held on Wenceslas Square. The mood was militant, calling for the downfall of the current government. Preceding the demonstration was a very angry, provocative counterdemonstration. Riot police were called, and arrests were made. You can witness the scene by watching "Ritualizing the Czech 'Velvet' Revolution."[443]

Later on the same day, the first Sametové Posvícení—literally, "Velvet Feast"—was scheduled. Since this event was more of a procession than a protest, organizers referred to it in English as "Velvet Carnival." Countering the demonstration and counterdemonstration, it was designed to transform anger into creativity, so its tone was playful, ironic, and gently iconoclastic. The idea of having such an event originated with Olga Věra Cieslarová, a student of religious studies and theater who studied Basel's Fasnacht, wrote a thesis about it, and then returned to Prague to create a similar festival, the first one happening in 2012. Musicians from Basel were enthused about the idea and sent a delegation from Switzerland to participate. The parade units were created by nongovernmental organizations (NGOs) and civic organizations, each with distinctive masks, music, and leaflets explaining their causes.

Shortly before the procession was to begin, the morning's labor demonstration flooded into the streets, surging toward the National Theater, where the Velvet Carnival was assembling. Because the police could not stop the massive crowd, carnival processants were forced to leave early, barely avoiding a collision on the streets. November 17 is sacred to Czech nationalism and identity; so are Wenceslas Square and the National Theater courtyard. Not only are the spaces competitively contested, but the time-space nexus is so powerful that any ritual actions occurring in them are markedly enhanced and warped.

Ritual timing concerns not only the group and its shared social clock but also individuals and their felt sense of timing. If you are in your forties, all your friends are married, and you have yet to undergo "that special day,"
p. 266 this postponement has consequences. It colors how you imagine the deferred or rejected ceremony—even ↳ the actual one, should you opt to undergo it. If you live in a retirement home for seniors and attend two or three funerals a month, the frequency changes the ethos of the rites. Perhaps they remind attendees of their own

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mortality, but such occasions also offer residents things they enjoy and anticipate: a bus ride, socializing, or special food.

Ritual time is not only about when a ritual occurs but also about how often. *Ritual regularity* is about the evenness of intervals between enactments. A ritual that happens every 150 years is regular, but it is also infrequent. A ritual that happens daily but at varying times and for varying lengths can feel quite irregular. Irregularity can be either a source of disorientation and therefore criticism or of surprise and therefore anticipation. *Ritual frequency* is about how often a ritual happens, and it affects participants' feelings about how special or quotidian an event is. Rituals that happen frequently elicit lower expectations, while rituals that happen infrequently elicit higher ones. The difference is like that of a staple contrasted with a dessert. Each works on embodied memory in a different way. Harvey Whitehouse distinguishes between rituals in *doctrinal* mode and those in *imagistic* mode. The former are routinized and high in frequency. They tend to elicit extensive exegesis, but they are also subject to the tedium effect. The latter are infrequent, highly arousing, generative of a conscious search for meaning, and more likely to create long-lasting, episodic memories.[444]

Ritual phases are chronological subunits. They can be mechanically marked by, say, drumbeats or clappers, or they can simply flow without benefit or necessity of explicit dividers. Sometimes they are recognized, named, and written out by leaders or teachers, who subdivide a ritual to facilitate the teaching and learning of it.[445] They can even be computer-generated.[446] Sometimes phases are discovered in analysis. Sometimes they are only felt or experienced by ritualists themselves, in which case the phases must be inferred and named by observers.

There has been a persistent tendency to conceptualize ritual phases as narrativelike (with a beginning, middle, and end), dramalike (with rising and falling, climactic action), or musiclike (therefore rhythmic), but such metaphors are not necessarily those of participants. Ritual accounts by observers can either loop by free association or chronicle sequences in order: This happens, that happens, and something else happens.[447] The subdivisions perceived by an observer may or may not match those of participants.

The fact that rites unfold in time means that when you try to film or take notes on one, you have little choice but to track it in a linear fashion from beginning to end, because that is how it eventuates. Even if you are scurrying in circles trying to study a festival in which there are multiple simultaneous events, the event itself, like a clock, still runs forward. Later you may code your notes into nonchronologically ordered constituents or edit footage in a nonlinear fashion, but initially, the enactment or performance, regardless of whether it alludes
p. 267 to a mythic time before time or to timeless acts of ancestors, moves relentlessly forward through time. In this
↳ respect, following a ritual is similar to reading a novel. The story may circle and cycle chronologically, but readers are expected by authors to turn pages one by one in chronological order. The difference is that ritual accounts are seldom narratively compelling in the way good novels are.

The theoretically inspired idea that rites of passage have preliminal, liminal, and postliminal phases is sometimes helpful, sometimes not. This threefold phasic scheme espoused by Arnold van Gennep, then developed by Victor Turner, may be useful for organizing articles about ritual, but seldom are ritual phases so neatly laid out. Often there are phases within phases. There are macro- and micro-phases, as well as recursive loops. The course of actual rituals often makes havoc out of the theory that rituals are three-phased. Even if one discovers three phases in an initiation rite, this discovery is no guarantee that they will show up in other initiations, much less other kinds of ritual.

Thinking of a ritual in terms of "rhythm" is probably more to the point but also less seductive than thinking of it as "narrative," because most of us nonmusicians would have difficulty identifying rhythmic patterns with any degree of accuracy. The temporal rhythm of a ritual may in fact be musical, but it is not necessarily musical, nor is it necessarily singular or linear. Just as spaces can overlap, creating a veritable palimpsest, so time—musical, mythical, and ritualistic—can loop. Ritual recursivity seems to invite musical metaphors.

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Although there are studies of music in ritual, there is little research on the rhythm or musicality of rituals themselves. The fact that rituals are so widely defined in terms of recurrence and repetition ought to make us wonder whether something other than metaphor-making is going on when people say the drum is Mother Earth's heartbeat or that practice is about assimilating ritual values into breath cycles or heartbeats. Is the notion of a ritual's rhythm metaphoric or literal? What's the connection between the rhythm of seasons, the rhythm of a ritual's unfolding, the rhythm of a piece of music within that ritual, and the rhythmicity of the ritual itself?

Ritual Objects

The paraphernalia of ritual can be minimal or enormous but always something of a puzzle. Which of these counts as a ritual object: an icon on an iconostasis? An icon in pilgrimage gift shop? An icon for sale in a flea market? A chalice? A chalice filled with wine? A chalice filled with beer? Money? Money in a collection plate? A piece of clothing once worn by your deceased child?

In "The Disposition of Cremation Ashes in the Netherlands," a video interview with Dutch researcher Meike Heessels, she tells the story of an ash-scattering in which a young boy accidentally spills some funerary ashes.[448] At first everyone is horrified, but then they begin to laugh and improvise, because the father, whose
p. 268 ashes are being released, was "like that." One kid says, "Oops, maybe that was his ↳ leg," and another retorts, "Oh, and there goes his heart." Mourners can treat them either way: Ashes are a person; ashes are not a person. Shortly after death, it's probably impossible to resolve your attitudes one way or the other. The laughing and joking express both feelings at once: He is alive and would enjoy this; he is dead and won't mind. Human ashes cross the boundary between life and death. They refuse to be cast out; families don't trash corpses. Ashes are as sacred and inviolable as living persons; otherwise first responders and soldiers wouldn't fight so hard to recover dead bodies and treat them with ceremonial respect.[449]

It is tempting to equate ritual objects with sacred objects, but the two are not identical. "Sacred" is about value; "ritual" is about use. "Sacred" means "ultimately valued," but there are penultimate things as well: treasures, memorabilia, and keepsakes. Ritual objects are implements actively used in rituals, but what about things merely occupying a ritual space? What about food eaten, food offered to gods, and food left over? And what about ritual implements carried beyond the ritual precincts? Are they still ritual tools? If a ritual object away from its home is treated ritually, it remains a ritual object. If it is treated as mere disposable stuff, it is not.

Not all rituals require paraphernalia. Some traditions play down the possession of material goods, but these traditions do not escape materiality altogether regardless of how vigorously ritual specialists espouse nonmaterial goals. While some traditions make a project of disengaging from materiality by dispensing with ritual hardware, minimizing costs, or descrying things tangible, other traditions accumulate sacred treasures, venerate icons, and invest in liturgical hardware. Either way, stuff accumulates and things deteriorate from neglect or protracted use. The laws of physics and chemistry apply even in the most sanctified settings. In the face of deterioration, and confronted by the possibility of theft, every group has to determine how to use and value material culture. Participants debate among themselves: Is ownership bad? Can sanctified property be deconsecrated, sold, given away, or traded? Should a sacred pipe be preserved in a glass case or be allowed to deteriorate naturally? A host of other questions arise with regard to iconic images: Are they semblances or embodiments? Is their veneration idolatrous?

How should devotees treat the statue of La Conquistadora when they are not displaying or parading "her," when not dressing and undressing "it"? Which is it, "her" or "it"? How should the statue be cared for? La Conquistadora, Our Lady of the Conquest, is the symbolic matrix of genealogical lines leading to some of the most prominent families around Santa Fe, New Mexico, and the Rio Grande valley. As symbolic mother, she is a source of cultural identity. Some who venerate her express great pride in their family trees and coats of arms.

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Contemplating the complex, heartfelt connections between this particular version of the Virgin Mary and New Mexico's Hispanic culture, some Santa Feans are moved to tears.[450]

Devotion to La Conquistadora is a way of sustaining loyalty to family lines. The Virgin Mother is the keystone of a family-centered cosmos. Those who express filial devotion to her are not only implicitly her knights and
p. 269 daughters but also children of ↳ the *conquistadores*. La Conquistadora is an ancient heirloom jointly possessed by a multitude of interlocking families. Hence, when they speak of "our" mother, they are doing more than using a customary term. La Conquistadora is "ours" in two senses: She is both an heirloom statue and a material embodiment of a spiritual mother.

For her papal coronation La Conquistadora's devotees sent out a formally printed invitation that began, "*Hijos mios* ..." ("My children ...") and continued as if it were a personal note from the Lady herself. This intimate, first-person style is exemplified by Angelico Chávez's *La Conquistadora: The Autobiography of an Ancient Statue*.[451] The book is written as if La Conquistadora herself had dictated it. As queen and lady she has champions and intermediaries, but as mother she speaks directly to her children. The dedication page of Chávez's *Autobiography* reads, "To the memory of these and scores of other 'Conquistadora' progenitors and their consorts."

Devotees say that La Conquistadora belongs to everyone in the Southwest, but this concept applies mainly to her role as queen and patroness. As mother, she belongs to Roman Catholics generally, especially to families claiming conquistador descent. The novena processions, during which she goes in procession from the cathedral to Rosario Cemetery, are times of family reunions and remembering the dead. So even though there is an outer circle of inclusivism allowing La Conquistadora to reign ceremonially like a civic queen over the city, there is also an inner circle of ethno-familial particularism. Publicly, she belongs to all residents regardless of race, color, or creed, but privately, devotees jealously guard La Conquistadora as one would a revered, aged mother. As a statue, she is "Catholic family property," although no one properly owns a mother, much less the Mother of God.

In ritual circumstances, the boundary between people and things can be extraordinarily fluid. Objects become subjects, and subjects, objects.[452] People are objectified, rendering them thinglike, and objects become animate, humanlike actors. Animated, they animate. Like spaces, things can live, or at least be said to be living. Receiving flowers and being showered with milk, they take initiative and confer blessings.

Animate and powerful ritual objects elicit care: This ring was your grandfather's; look after it well. That staff belonged to the deceased archbishop; hang it there; do not use it. This image was painted by a saint in a state of deep prayer. For twelve generations this shofar was passed from father to son, all rabbis, so do not drop it. Not only "material culture," such things are also "materialized spirituality." They incarnate (in stone or wood rather than flesh) what they signify.

Ritually animated things are often wrapped in stories and myths resembling biographies of famous persons.[453] Treasured finds are stolen and sold like slaves, hauled across frontiers, and then shown off in museums, originally sanctuaries of colonialism. In such settings, other people's ritual objects are encountered by tourists gazing at bartered ceremonial goods displayed in oak-trimmed glass cases. As museum pieces, ritual objects are singularized, construed as one of a kind, therefore precious, maybe even priceless. Displaying them touts a
p. 270 nation's power by ↳ demonstrating the range of its travels and the elevation of its taste. Viewing them defines a class of cultural elite.

A fetish is a potent object evoking ritualized behavior. The word arose in the seventeenth century among Portuguese traders, who used it to refer to talismans, probably from the Guinea coast of Africa. So it connoted any object that *other people* regarded as potent. Later, in the nineteenth century, the term picked up two additional meanings. Freudians gave it a sexual turn: A fetish was an object that stirred an irrational erotic desire focused on an object or body part. Then Marx and his followers used the phrase "fetishism of

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commodities" to describe the dynamics of mystification surrounding exchange. A commodity was fetishized when a transcendent charge was attributed to it, resulting in a value beyond that of the labor required to produce it.[454] The reverse process is commodification, which takes place when something sacred (valued for noneconomic reasons) is reduced to its economic value. Commodified objects are produceable, often reproduceable and sellable, therefore regarded as common.

Goods crossing boundaries develop complex economies of exchange. Gifts go from being mine to being yours. Food moves from outside to inside, from being not-me to being me. Sacrifices, sometimes in the form of food, move from humans to deities, who in turn bestow gifts on humans who themselves are transformed into sacrificial material. So it is not enough merely to identify and label ritual objects. Students of ritual must follow the migration of paraphernalia, studying how their life cycles are caught up in processes of exchange. A thing may travel not only in space but also in status from, say, being a mere commodity to becoming a singular, therefore valued object to being an icon.

Icons are a particularly rich source of insights for reflecting on ritual objects. The video "A Brush with Silence" follows George Kordis, a Greek iconographer, teaching Western students the art of painting (technically, "writing") icons.[455] Orthodox Christianity and icon painting are often romanticized in North America, but traditional icon writing can be more doggedly practical or piously liturgical than romanticism usually allows. This workshop was for beginners, and its tone was practical. The most mystical dimension was the insistent whistling wind outside. George, although a serious Orthodox practitioner, is no romantic. You can see him joking as he edits students' strokes and remixes their colors. The workshop's ethos is not liturgical. In fact, its most ritualized activity was that of checking cell phones and watches. Since quotidian ritualization rules, the video is wrapped in the driving rhythms of Patrick Lee's "Quittin' Time."[456] Much of the day was marked by instructional pedagogy and collaborative chatter, along with waves of consternation and delight. The workshop produced a set of almost-finished icons, along with much inadvertent art created on blotters and plates of glass used for mixing colors. By the day's end, most participants had fallen into silence, "quittin' time," the stilled state of mind and spirit in which sacred art can begin, because, finally, in these circumstances, a painter can almost hear the stroke of the brush.

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By the end of the day were the icons holy? Most participants said not, even though the subject matter was. After a later workshop some said that finishing the painting at home in silence moved the paintings in that direction, but that the paintings would probably only be sanctified by relocation into a church or by protracted meditative use. So whether a painting becomes a ritual object isn't only a matter of its formal qualities, content, or conditions of its production but also of its use.

Narrowly defined, *icons* are ritually executed representations of holy beings (God, Christ, the saints, angels) painted with egg tempera on wood in a Byzantine style cultivated by Orthodox Christianity. The non-Orthodox West typically refers to icons as if they are objects designed to be seen, but in practice icons are also touched, carried, addressed, offered incense or candles, and even kissed. Apt illustrations of the way one kind of ritually framed sensory activity triggers the other senses, icons are experienced not only visually but also in tactile, kinesthetic, auditory, olfactory, and gustatory ways.

As a hedge against idolatry, traditional Orthodox icons are deliberately flat rather than three-dimensional. Traditional iconographers resisted the move toward realism that perspective offered. Even so, for iconophiles icons were considered to incarnate, or embody, divine reality. Icons did not merely refer to something sacred or only remind worshippers of the divine.

For iconoclasts, however, icons were false substitutes, idols. Broadly conceived, *iconoclasm* means the critique of iconicity, the refusal to treat something as sacred. Narrowly understood, it refers to two brief periods of eighth-century Byzantine history. Illustrating the fierceness of the debates and attacks, a church council in 754 declared:

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> If anyone ventures to represent the divine image of the Word after the Incarnation with material colours, let him be anathema!
>
> The evil custom of assigning names to the images does not come down from Christ and the Apostles and the holy Fathers; nor have these left behind then, any prayer by which an image should be hallowed or made anything else than ordinary matter.
>
> The only admissible figure of the humanity of Christ, however, is bread and wine in the holy Supper. This and no other form, this and no other type, has he chosen to represent his incarnation. Bread he ordered to be brought, but not a representation of the human form, so that idolatry might not arise.[457]

For the iconoclasts the only acceptable icon was the liturgy itself, because in it Christ, the image of God, was actually present in bread and wine and not merely hinted at by representations. Although visual images such as
p. 272 paintings and statues were unacceptable, actions (kinesthetic, tactile, and gustatory) enacted with food ↳ (bread, wine) were not. In short, early iconoclasm did not apply to every thing or every action.

Iconophilia and iconoclasm are not confined to theological and liturgical debates of eighth-century Christianity. Broadly conceived, an icon is any venerated image, not only of a divine being but also of a beloved musician, vaunted movie star, celebrated sports hero, or lionized politician. By epitomizing the aspirations of devotees, iconic personages receive homage. Icons in this sense are not limited to statues or things holy. Even photos can become iconic. Iconicity can be attributed to a family photo capturing "the last time the family was all together," or to a journalistic photo of a crucial historical moment in Tiananmen Square. Journalistic photos become iconic when they become widely recognizable, shaping attitudes or subsequent photographic practices and sometimes even determining political decisions. Family photos become iconic not merely by resemblance but also by the power they exercise on behavior. Family members don't only look at treasured pictures; they touch, carry, frame, hang, and even kiss them.[458]

In the documentary *Looking for an Icon*, Geoffrey Batchen, who teaches the history of photography, observes that echoes of Christian art often appear in iconic photos not because photographers decide to embed such allusions but because their perceptions are conditioned by compositional practices that suffuse art history.[459] In the same documentary, Italian photographer-designer Oliviero Toscani remarks, "The church used religious icons to give expression to its power. Later on, art was put in the service of politics and put in the service of industry, in order to promote and sell products." Later Toscani concludes, "So communication is an instrument of authority. And an authority that wants to assert its power has to create icons. That means that everyone who believes in an icon is a servant. We are servants of authority."[460] In short, icons, whether paintings in Orthodox Christianity or photos in secular journalism, are not merely seen or touched; they also act.

Senior citizens in Glasgow produced a series of photos called *Iconic Moments of the Twentieth Century*.[461] One picture shows a senior citizen with his pistol to the head of another senior, who is facing the camera. The picture is a parody, but it reinforces the iconicity of the original photo by asking viewers whether they recall Eddie Adams's 1968 picture of police chief Nguyen Ngoc Loan executing a Vietcong guerrilla during the Vietnam War.[462] Younger viewers may not get the seniors' allusion, in fact, might not even recognize the original photo if it were shown to them. The possibility of nonrecognition forces us to ask: If iconic images are neither universal nor eternal, what is the cultural and historical purview of an iconic painting or photo? Iconicity is as much a function of contexts as of the contents of pictures themselves. Religious icons and iconic photos may be widely recognized, but they have a limited constituency as well as a lifespan. If someone were to test us by describing some iconic photos, we may recognize a few, but not all of them, and even though we may recognize the photos themselves, we may not remember either the photographer or the situation.

p. 273 Like any object, a ritual object is a sensorily perceived medium. The media of traditional icon painting are egg yolk, water, and wine on wood, so we oversimplify by speaking in the singular, "medium." Even the apparently simple medium of an Orthodox icon is, in fact, a multimedium. Debates over icons, whether ancient or

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contemporary, are struggles to comprehend the multiplicity of media and their way of making sense. Think of the ways we use the term “medium” and its derivatives. A *medium* is a sticky substance (for example, egg white) that binds color for artistic use. The senses *mediate* data to our brains. Organizations that broadcast news electronically are *media*. Adepts who enter trance to communicate with spirits are *mediums*. Any means of communication that operates in a middle position, thereby linking two parties, is a medium. Like words spoken or images transmitted, objects, texts, places, and clothing are also media of communication insofar as they bear messages. With this broader understanding of media, the central problem is less that of defining terms than of distinguishing and relating various media and understanding their different ways of mobilizing the senses. What happens to a picture when it is set alongside a text, and what happens to the text as well? Why do televisions seem out of place in one ritual but not in another? Is the textuality of text-messaging the same as the textuality of a Koran passage or that of a textbook? Is a virtual wedding in Second Life as efficacious as an embodied wedding in “First Life” (this life)? If couples married in Second Life prefer to minimize the differences between Second and First Life, why, in defending their video gaming, do adolescent players of violent video games prefer to maximize the differences between onscreen and in-world violence?

Objects are not just “there.” The senses mediate them to humans through the brain. All knowledge is mediated —in fact, doubly so: not only through the brain's sensory apparatus but also through what we now call “the media.” The media include not only electronic broadcasts and websites but also older media such as broadsheets and newspapers, ancient media such as paintings and statues, and things we don’t usually think of as media, such as clothing and carts. In politicized ritual settings media tend to multiply, and as they multiply, they net other senses. A medium, them, ramifies into multimedia, and multimedia elicit multisensory perception.

Icons are sacralized images, and holy books are sacralized writings. The dynamics of the two kinds of ritual objects are similar. You can carry, touch, or kiss a book as you might an icon. A sacred text may exist only orally in performance, but it may be objectified into a tangible codex or intangible but visible electronic medium. In each instance, sacred texts speak, assisted by their human animators. People not only touch sacred texts; they also listen to them. Like icons, holy texts display personlike characteristics, offering not only consolation but directives: Do this, don’t do that. Although they may be objects in need of dusting, they are also subjects that act. Like people, books “tell” stories. As with icons, holy books are also acted upon, becoming bones of contention. What they say is incontestable, therefore infinitely contested.

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Ritual Languages

Literate as well as oral traditions ritualize sound, mainly in the form of speech and music, both of which may be accompanied by sonic markers such as the sounds of clappers or bells. By demarcating a beginning, ending, transition, or high point, sounds can lay out a narrative track even when they don’t contain narratives. Other sounds such as animal cries, sacred syllables, and nonlinguistic ecstatic utterances are widespread. Although ritual sounds are typically prescribed, they may also be improvised. Suffusing deliberate ritual sounds are ambient sounds in ritual, the ordinary, incidental “noise” generated by ritual activity such as shuffling feet, turning pages, and restless children. Ordinarily, participants tune out ambient sounds as most of us do the white noise in a restaurant. Ambient sounds may, however, constitute a kind of sonic metacommentary on the ritual itself. The methodological difficulty of studying them is like that of trying to read uncodified body language: How do interpreters know when their interpretations are off-base?

Two videos in the online album “Ritual Creativity, Improvisation, and the Arts” can nuance our grasp of ritual language by complicating it.[463] In “Improvising Spiritually” two women are vocally improvising in a soirée. Dominique Gauthier uses words and seems to be telling bits of a story. Victoria di Giovanni is vocalizing, using lots of rich vowel sounds but no words. In Dominique's case a listener can speculate about what the words

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mean. There seem to be characters and a social situation, but not quite a plot. In Victoria's case, listeners could say how the sounds coming out of her mouth made them feel or how they imagined Victoria felt as she sang, but only by free association could anyone say what her singing was "about." However, fellow student Shadrack Jackman exclaims enthusiastically and repeatedly that both are "spiritual." Questioned by me, he explains what he means by this word. He won't agree that it is "ritualistic," because to him that word suggests a scripted performance, and these two were spiritual because they were unscripted and because the two women made themselves vulnerable.

In "A Vulnerable Moment in Vocal Improvisation," I interview Victoria as she watches her own improvisation on video.[464] She can't explain what happened except to say that she was improvising sounds while watching another classmate who was moving to her vocalizations. There was a feedback loop between them. To her, the important thing about the improvisation was not meaning but effect, tears among audience members.

What constitutes a ritual word, ritual sound, ritual music, or ritual noise is not immediately evident from an analysis of the formal properties of sounds themselves. The difference between meaningful sound and meaningless noise is a matter of intention and definition, and also a matter of perspective and reception. When a milk steamer goes on at a local coffee shop, rendering the lyrics of the piped-in music impossible to decipher,
p. 275 that sound, the inescapable accompaniment to the ↳ act of making a latte, is not obviously ritualistic. In fact, for most of us it would be extraneous not only to ritual but even to the event of going out for coffee. The sounds, however, are ritualistic for the writer who arrives every morning at 6:30 a.m. for her coffee and writing ritual.[465] She calls it that. The barista notices the "morning lady" enjoying the sound of the frother and one day overhears her describing it as "music to my ears." Later the lady tells him that the sound is the trigger for her morning "writing ritual." So, with no further cueing and without further planning, discussion, or analysis, he "plays" his machine, and they celebrate the early morning hours. The woman is "religious" about her writing; the barista is "religious" about serving his "Starbuckians" what their brains crave. The morning lady could have spoken differently, becoming irritated by the frothing "racket," but she doesn't. Is the sonic interchange at Starbuck's ritualization? Is the lady merely turning phrases? The determining factors are not only what she says but also what she does. Is she cultivating core values? Does she follow the form, as a devotee might do puja in a temple, or does she take a seat and listen, as one might do in a concert?

Using the rhetoric of religion and ritual in a coffee shop and coupling it with repetitive, highly valued behavioral patterns is not all that different from myth-making in ritual. Sound is often mythologized or mystified: The sound of a Native American drum is Mother Earth's heartbeat; the sound of a chanted "OM" has causal, even curative, force. Scientific research seems to confirm that sound, beyond its role as a vehicle for linguistic meaning, can exert formative influence.[466] Rhythmic pounding can induce trance, and music can change or create with such force that it can inspire people go to war. Think about the highly mythologized bagpipe or the fife and drum combination. Sound instruments can entrain sympathetic resonances in objects, including human bodies. Receptors vibrate "sympathetically" with emitters. The Mozart effect, popularized as the claim that listening to classical music makes you smarter, has been roundly criticized.[467] Still, less grandiose versions of this basic insight have been demonstrated. Certain frequencies, rhythms, or genres of music have verifiable and predictable effects. If an apt musical ambience can sprout more okra and zucchini seeds over a seventy-two-hour period than mere "pink" noise can, the sound-action and sound-feeling connections in ritual are worth studying.[468] The scientific and artistic reception of *Your Brain on Music* suggests that "your brain on ritual sound" is a viable research topic.[469]

Languages, even when written, remain tacitly sonic. Sometimes the investment in language is so heavy that ritual itself is construed as essentially verbal and linguistic. If you think that rituals act out meaning and that meaning consists of words, it is tempting to play up ritual language, to treat rituals as mere frames for words rather than the other way around. Catholics "say" Mass, and Navahos "sing" their ceremonies. In both instances words are understood to have the power to act. It is even more tempting to treat ritual as a kind of language if you believe words can make the world or bring about fundamental transformations. Even though

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p. 276 my “periodic table” of elements distinguishes sounds from actions, nothing stops either practitioners ↳ or theorists from construing speech as a kind of action or even as kind of object. After all, making a sound *is* an action, and words not only declare facts or convey meanings; they also accomplish tasks. Words in ritual settings describe, state, narrate, and even question, but one of their most distinctive functions is that of doing things. “I pronounce you husband and wife” is not merely a pious wish or a description of a fact but, rather, the performance of a deed. Saying so makes it so.[470]

List 14 contains some of the kinds of language that ritual studies scholars examine.

List 14. Kinds of Ritual Language

- canonical, or sacred, texts
- ritual texts
- the words of songs, hymns, chants
- performative utterances, declarations
- authoritative oral speech: homilies, sermons, exhortations
- prayer, petition
- praise, thanksgiving
- readings of sacred texts, poetry, letters, etc.
- testimony (personal narrative)
- magical incantations
- ecstatic utterances, in-the-spirit speech
- speaking for or as a deity, possession talk
- words of consecration
- words of decorum, e.g., introductions, recognitions
- facilitating directives, announcements, rubrics
- incidental talk, e.g., gossip, greetings, polite exchanges
- official, public words of exposition, exegesis, or interpretation
- unofficial, informal commentary by participants
- behind-the-scenes shoptalk among leaders
- liturgical theologies, theories of ritual

Performative utterances are sometimes singled out as the quintessential form of ritual language, leaving the impression that “real” rituals necessarily and effectively transform things, but such performative pronouncements are rare, leaving many other linguistic forms to be identified and studied. An exclusive focus on ritual words, either performative utterances or canonical texts, can deafen us to words and deeds outside ritual. Words before and after rituals, along with offstage verbal exchanges, are worth examining because they are often more candid. If we do not study unofficial commentaries and incidental talk, we will never know

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whether they are mere echoes of the rituals themselves or implicitly subversive countercurrents. Participants may be excluded from professional shoptalk, but scholars should tune in to it, asking what it might "say" about the rituals themselves.

p. 277 In addition to documenting words before, after, or about a ritual, we scholars should ask whether performative utterances and canonical words actually do what either clergy or theorists claim they do. The relationship between performative utterances ("I pronounce you husband and wife") and magic ("Be healed") is complex. The distance between a pronouncement and command is small, but how can we explain it? Is it enough to say that performative utterances depend on prior social agreement and that magical utterances are either delusional or just figurative ways of speaking and doing? One way of characterizing magic is as "words that compel," but compelling is not the only way things work. Prayers often contain petitions. Although praying participants might deny having the power to compel a divine being, they may believe that things are more likely to happen if accompanied by praise and polite petitions. Prayer is not altogether dissimilar to magic, since the difference is that between influencing and causing.

The opposite of words that do things are words that don't. Nominalism ("name-ism") is the view that a word is merely a *vocus flatus*, a mouth-fart, or, more politely, a blowing out of breath. Nominalism holds that a word is an arbitrary label rather than an efficacious agent. The contrary view holds that words, especially proper names, are causal agents. In some religious traditions—Orthodox Judaism, for instance—one does not write or say the holy name but utters a circumlocution, because the name is connected with the reality. One can hold a nominalist view of cursing as well as praying. If someone "uses God's name in vain," by cursing your mother or damning you to hell, how do you regard the utterance? As just so much hot air? As a desecration? As affecting the very being of you and your mom?

Even though languages are sonic, they leave sediment. Like implements and edifices, ritual texts are a major form of residue deposited by long-lived traditions. Theological study has privileged the study of texts not only because they have endured but also because they contain written language, privileged as an enduring echo of divine words. Although objects and spaces may be treated as sacred and therefore approached ritually, texts have long been privileged by the so-called religions of the book. As a consequence, ritual studies scholarship on literate traditions has tended to be textually preoccupied. For centuries, theology, the religious study of religion, has been book-centered. Not only have books been the focus of meditative study, the documentary sources of law and ethics, and the authoritative repositories of ritual knowledge; they have also been the primary means of demonstrating competence in the study of ritual. All of these activities have benefited from—but also been trapped by—the sacralization and ritualization of words in books.

A peculiarity of religious life is that authorities who worry over the idolizing of material objects don't always worry about the sacralizing of language in its many manifestations: sacred texts, prophetic declarations, inspired creeds, words of consecration. Even secular North American newspapers seem to privilege words, for example, by referring to weddings as the "exchanging of vows." So it is worth noticing whether words, when
p. 278 compared with objects, are regarded as equally facilitating or ↳ inhibiting of human-divine communication. It is worth inquiring what else besides words acts, and how it does so. Music, for instance, acts; it moves bodies and emotions. If music can rouse inert feet into tapping out rhythms, how does this power compare with that of a ritual pronouncement's ability to bond or a prayer's capacity for moving divine beings? Words may "do," but so does music, so do places, and so do things; clearly language is not unique in its capacity to do work.

Sacred texts such as the Torah, Bible, and Koran contain ritual accounts as well as warrant ritual performances. Although in their respective traditions each of these is theologically *the one* privileged book, other books sit alongside and, in fact, within them. Each book is a really a collection of smaller books. In practice each text is supplemented and extended by other authoritative but noncanonical texts, some of which also shape ritual enactments. Although liturgics, like ritual studies and the history of religions, has recently begun conducting research on ritual performances, the bulk of writing and research continues to be on historic ritual texts.

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“Ritual text,” like “sacred text,” is an oversimplified label, since many ritual and sacred texts contain other kinds of material. *Seder Nashim*, which governs Jewish marriage and thereby weddings, is legal and ethical as well as ritualistic in import. This mixing of what we consider separate genres is typical of many traditions, so it is not always easy to know what counts or does not count as a ritual text.

Ritual texts facilitate ritual performances in at least two ways. In one of these ways a community decides that performance is served by a mnemonic device, so a script is prepared as an alternative to memorization. Texts used as scripts sit *behind* performances like a prompter's notes or playwright's script sits behind a performed play. In a second way ritual texts appear *in* rituals, read aloud by leaders, tracked silently by followers, touched, fanned, elevated, or revered. They function like ritual objects. However, these alternatives (text behind a performance, text as prop in a performance) are not always acceptable. Because scripts can be a distraction or substitute, Navahos and Hindus, for example, lay great emphasis on learning by rote or heart. Other traditions, valuing spontaneity or openness to the movement of the spirit, also shun text-driven ritual performances.[471]

Saint Lydia's is a “dinner church,” a small, fairly new congregation meeting in the Brooklyn Zen Center. Its central ritual, which includes cooking and eating a meal, is at once experimental and traditional. In a video of one of their services, Emily Scott, pastoral minister, delivers a brief, read sermon.[472] However, it is completed, responded to, and amplified by a “collective sermon” in which other community members react, confess, ruminate, and storytell. The process maintains a clergy/parishioner distinction—she reads her previously prepared part—but it also democratizes the process by giving others their say. The homiletical portion of the liturgy is a hybrid—partly textualized, partly improvised.

In historical and archaeological research, ritual texts are sometimes referred to as either primary sources or the sources of ritual. There is nothing wrong with this usage provided you realize that textual sources are only the
p. 279 immediate or accessible ↳ sources rather than the ultimate sources. The ultimate sources of ancient or long-lived rituals are seldom known. In any case, ritual texts are just as commonly the effects of ritual as they are the causes of it. Even in the case of recent ritual scripts, it is not common to sign them as one signs a book, claiming authorship to it. Anonymity, borrowing, and collective or cumulative authorship of ritual scripts remain the rule even in literate cultures. Often there are intermediate sources—in effect, a chain leading from actual performances to peoples’ memories and oral traditions, then to the inscription of rituals into print or in today's megachurches, writ large onscreen.

Many rituals are cued without benefit of writing. People know the words, and cues are delivered in ways other than written scripting. However, one of the marks of so-called high, literate liturgical traditions is that they are more book-guided than the low ones are. Both ritual performance and ritual revision are approached as if written and read words are more central than performed actions or as if the words *are* the actions. In Christian liturgical texts one sometimes finds rubrics (printed in red) or italics that, although they direct action, are considered secondary. A priest or parishioner does not speak these cues aloud but, rather, does what they direct.

A basic rule of field research on ritual, then, is never to assume that texts and performances mirror each other even if ritual leaders say they perform according to the book, rule, or tradition. Maybe they do, but it is entirely possible that they do not. Ritual texts may or may not be followed, and they may be followed in some respects but not in others. Participants can adhere to them selectively without even recognizing that they are being selective. Queried, informants may describe what they think they should do instead of describing what they actually do. They may not even notice that they are not following their own ritual books.

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Ritual Groups

Rituals are built on affiliation. Friends join the same civic club or sorority. Only those of a certain age can be initiated. Only those able to afford an exorbitant membership fee can participate in the rites of decorum at a local golf club. Men only. Women only. Whites only. Adults only. We can't study a ritual without understanding the groups, both formal and informal, that run it, and without understanding how those groups interconnect with the social dynamics of the larger, surrounding society.

The collective element of a ritual can be so broad that it may not seem to be merely a constituent of ritual but rather the whole of it. The social scientific study of ritual is often so concentrated on the social dynamics of collectives that rituals themselves tend to become incidental to anthropological and sociological accounts of them; the study of ritual is the study of collectives. I put this element last not to say it is less important but so that the other elements are not short-changed. However we label ritual's collective element, list 15 lays out several considerations for students of ritual.

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List 15. Collective Considerations in the Study of Ritual

- social distinctions, e.g., gender, class, ethnicity, nationality, age; the ritual buttressing or subversion of these; ritually reinforced inclusion and exclusion
- the political dimensions of ritual: community-, tribe-, and nation-building
- the exercise of power, the pursuit of justice, laws, ethics
- hierarchy, equality, inequality
- the economics of ritual, exchange, gift giving, sacrifice
- collective agency, ritual leaders, ritual followers, ritual facilitators
- the cultural patterns of collective behavior that permeate and frame a ritual
- social movements and cultures insofar as they permeate rituals and ritual systems
- ritually supported ideologies, e.g., those that shape state-building, revolutions, and other concerted social efforts

Theoretically, one has to account for the fact that ritualists don't only act individually; they also act together, forming groups and subgroups. Ritualists have social ties outside their rituals, and they transmit ritual know-how among themselves and to newcomers. Rituals forms and the social structures for their transmission frequently outlive the actors who inhabit them.

There is no satisfactory way to name this element, so, as with the others, I have chosen the simplest label I could find. You can photograph a ritual group. A divorced dad and his daughter dressed up for Halloween trick-or-treating constitutes a ritual group. There are other kinds of collective actors in Halloween celebrations: roving bands of teenagers, neighbors and their kids, extended families. They utilize ritual elements such as objects (costumes, candy, lights, and decorations) and verbal formulas ("Trick or treat" and "Thank you"). They use spaces, sidewalks and front doors, in a distinctive manner. Typically, kids perform front stage while adults, some costumed, some not, hold the backstage by waiting on sidewalks as guardian-witnesses of front-door performances.

There is more to Halloween than the holiday itself, the expected actions, the spatial choreography, or the accumulated stuff. Behind the candy and plastic jack-o-lanterns are organizations: businesses that

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manufacture and market sweets; city councils that pass by-laws to protect the innocent; churches that rail against these "pagan" practices hoping to displace them with proper worship; and civic organizations aspiring to transform commercialized Halloween practices into newly imported Day of the Dead processions. Insofar as businesses serve holidays, they are temporary ritual organizations, but organizations, unlike groups, are not photographable. You can take a picture of the front of a Nestlé factory or *gudwara* (Sikh place of worship), but that's only the shell of the organization, not the organization itself. This is both the advantage and disadvantage of the category "group."

Sustained and transmitted, a ritual event or holiday can ramify, pulling groups and organizations into its orbit. Its gravitational energy can constellate groups into organizations, and when organizations endure, generating
p. 281 a widely recognized ideology ↳ coupled with ritualized behavior and a set of moral values, the result is an institution. Institutions, organizations, and other forms of collectivity generate what we usually call "society" or used to call more polemically "the system." Although you can conceptualize or even diagram a society or social system, you cannot video one. At best you can symbolize it by recording a conversation among ritual leaders gathered around a table or by taking a picture of a group of elders sitting on the ground. Like impressive long-standing buildings, they may serve as visual stand-ins for the whole society, but they do not constitute it no matter how much power they have.

Whereas organizations come and go, institutions are supposed to be lasting. Ritual actors can die off, but something is still left standing: an institution.[473] New ritualists can enter it, and it is passed on. The stuff passed on consists of the knowledge, skills, attitudes, patterns, and values, as well as the artifacts and behaviors that encode them. We usually call this "culture." Like "ritual" and "religion," the concept is incessantly debated, defined, and redefined. Some advocate dumping all three ideas, but they keep coming back, even in the vocabularies of those who argue for their summary dismissal. Among the reputable but debatable definitions are these:

> - Alfred L. Kroeber and Clyde Kluckhohn: "Culture consists of patterns, explicit and implicit, of and for behavior acquired and transmitted by symbols, constituting the distinctive achievement of human groups, including their embodiments in artifacts; the essential core of culture consists of traditional (i.e., historically derived and selected) ideas and especially their attached values; culture systems may, on the one hand, be considered as products of action, on the other, as conditioning elements of further action."[474]
> - Clifford Geertz: [Culture is] "an historically transmitted pattern of meanings embodied in symbols, a system of inherited conceptions expressed in symbolic forms by means of which men communicate, perpetuate, and develop their knowledge about and their attitudes toward life."[475]
> - Fred Plog and Daniel Bates: [Culture is] "the system of shared beliefs, values, customs, behaviours, and artifacts that the members of society use to cope with their world and with one another, and that are transmitted from generation to generation through learning."[476]

Rituals are contained by ambient cultures, but they also contain internal cultures, and these are necessary for the survival of both an institution and its rituals. Ritual organizations and institutions, like businesses, persist by generating organizational cultures. The Santa Fe Fiesta is a recurring three-day event performed by actors of various sorts. When organizers and actors go home each year, the event dies. As with most deaths, this one leaves remains—memories, photos, videos, and purchased goods—but these remains are not enough to resurrect the fiesta. It comes to life each year because there are organizations and institutions (the Fiesta
p. 282 Council, ↳ the Caballeros de Vargas, the city of Santa Fe, the Roman Catholic Church) working on the event throughout the year. Although they must collaborate for the fiesta to happen, each has its own identity. As a result, the groups sometimes disagree and argue. Although they generate the semblance of a common fiesta

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culture atop the multiculture of Santa Fe, each group has its own organizational culture. Large, multinational organizations may even have subcultures, such as that of CEOs in contrast to that of custodial staff.

Interviewees in two Caribbean Carnival videos, “Judging the Junior Parade” and “The Toronto Revellers,” speak of the yearly festival as a “cultural” event.[477] Although none of them defines “culture” formally, their assumptions are largely in line with these anthropological definitions. Participants talk about songs, music, and costumes but also about attitudes, values, and beliefs, about “our ways of doing things.” They also assume that culture is passed down historically and can be deliberately taught as well as absorbed in food and conversation. Both women, Marion Magloire, maitre (mother) of the Revellers, and Marline Jones, judge and head-judge-in-training, are active culture-producers, not mere consumers. Having long participated in mas bands (“masquerade groups”), Marline and her compatriots also judge cultural performances on streets, stages, and runways, as well as assess material culture in the form of costumes and floats. The “Judging” video catches Marline while she is formally evaluating the Junior Parade, and Marion, in the “Revellers” video, is helping assemble Junior Revellers for parading down Jane Street toward Finch Avenue. In 2011, the Junior Revellers won first place in their competition. Similar competitions mark the adult parades as well.

The social dynamics preceding and during the Toronto Caribbean Carnival are complex, because the mas bands, which run for most of the year, can crosscut or connect diverse groups: youth and adult, immigrants from different Caribbean islands, people from different religious groups, and longtime residents from different neighborhoods and social classes. For the sake of the annual event there is an organizational culture generating (and generated by) the Toronto Caribbean Carnival, but below it are many subcultures. At any given event or moment, celebrants can mute the one and accent the other.

Organizational cultures, whether they infuse businesses, volunteer organizations, or ritual groups, typically underwrite divisions of labor, thus of power. Not every person can participate in every aspect of every ritual. There are requirements of qualification and status, differently priced tickets of admission, and privileged locations. It sometimes seems that rituals are deliberately designed for the purpose of creating not only insiders and outsiders but also hierarchies of insiders: You can come in; you can’t; you can, but you must sit over there behind that curtain; we wear this but you must wear that; we don’t eat this but those others do, so they can’t come in, and we don’t sit with them. Groups create rituals that enshrine their values. The values seem naturally to underwrite the group that perpetuates the rites. This circularity can be so tight that it seems natural and given, thus impenetrable and unbreakable.

p. 283 Some groups seem more like givens than others. Kinship and gender groups seem more natural than class or nationality. You don’t get to choose your mother or father, or even your daughter or cousin. They are not very changeable; you can’t divorce your cousin. Even though one may be born into a class or nation, people sometimes do manage to change their allegiances. But kinship is not quite as given or simple as it seems. Half-siblings, stepsiblings, adoptions, god-parenting, and ritual kinship complicate and compromise the seeming naturalness of kinship. In addition, your gender or income level, however changeable in theory, can make it difficult for you to escape your class or nation, making them practically unalterable.

Just as rituals necessarily imply a sociology and anthropology, they also imply a politics and economics. Rituals cost. In 2011 the average American wedding cost $27,000 ($65,824 in New York City).[478] In 2012 the average cost of a funeral in the United States was around $10,000.[479] President Barack Obama’s first swearing-in ceremony cost $1.24 million, but with the extras, the total bill was $170 million. Because rituals cost, they have an economics, a way of accumulating and distributing the media of exchange, a way of reckoning debt and ensuring fairness or reciprocity.[480] Even if grain, money, or pigs are not involved in formal ritual transactions, gifts and sacrifices often are, and even if they are not, time and labor are. Even if there are no tickets to buy and rituals appear to be freely offered services, donations or contributions are probably expected. A ritual ethic can rail against money, arguing for a barter system, but there is no avoiding an economic undertow.

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People sometimes resist the notion that money or its equivalent is necessarily involved in ritual, especially if the rituals are religious, but it is worth considering the possibility that, because money itself is literally worthless, even its exchange is a ritualized act. The substitutionary logic—this stands for that and therefore can be traded for or used instead of that—is one of the core principles of ritual the world over. Money is not just necessary to run most rituals; money *is* a ritual object.

Not only do rituals cost, and costing itself displays a ritualistic dynamic, but people sometimes buy or own rituals. There are obvious ways—ritual books like the *Book of Common Prayer* are copyrighted or held under letters patent—but there are subtle ways as well. Say you are a "keeper" of a particular ritual. As custodian, you not only serve but also control, not only sacrificing time and labor to perpetuate the rite but also profiting from the relationship.[481] Rituals, however much they may be spiritual events, are also commodities bought, sold, and traded.

Ritual Structures and Processes

Whether or not a theorist can satisfactorily name the elements of ritual, they interact, generating a whole ritual. But what is the nature of this whole? Scholars who study ritual frequently speak of it as either a "structure" or as "structured." "Elements," especially when imagined as building blocks, sounds similarly static.
p. 284 ↳ But ritual elements and structures are only apparently unchanging. The difference between the structures and elements of ritual, on the one hand, and the dynamics of ritual, on the other, is relative, like the difference between a dramatically sweeping second hand and a stubby but faithfully moving hour hand.

However inert elements may appear when divided into spheres on a chart; they overlap, interacting and generating ritual processes. Ritual "parts" are abstractions momentarily isolated for the sake of analysis. In this sense the elements are not real, and neither are whole rituals. No one experiences a whole ritual, any more than one experiences a ritual part in isolation. One's experience of a ritual is like one's experience of any event (e.g., an auto accident or a concert): It is a "take" on that event, a framed selection shot from a particular angle. Because attention drifts, perspectives are blocked, and interests are vested, the whole has to be inferred or imagined. So when one interprets a ritual, a crucial question is which parts are allowed to stand in for the whole. The process is not very different from selecting twelve of two hundred photos, shot across forty years, to represent the life of a deceased relative at that person's funeral.

To say that ritual studies is the study of rituals is more an aspiration than a description. What we usually write about are aspects of a ritual from one or two perspectives. The point in suggesting that descriptions, like interpretations, are partial, tendentious, or vested is not to scare off interpreters but to elicit a degree of humility. It is essential that you attempt to see the forest, not just count the trees, but since the whole eludes everyone's grasp, the only choice is to construct its semblance using gathered documentation, recalled memories, and active imaginations. Having done so, you take up this element or that function, not all the elements or all the functions.

Breaking out a ritual into its elements isn't only for theory-building. There are methodological uses as well. Using the elements, I set up a shot list for the Santa Fe Fiesta (see Appendix 13: Shot List for Santa Fe Fiesta). A shot list is not a storyboard. Storyboards follow a narrative arc: Shoot this, then this, and finally that. And storyboards are visual; on the basis of hand-drawn sketches, storyboards suggest visual perspectives and ways of composing shots. A storyboard for fiesta would include at least as many elements are there are events, probably a lot more. By contrast, my elemental shot list was categorical rather than chronological. In effect, it says to a fieldworker, "Don't forget this; remember that."

Partway into the shooting of the fiesta, I began cataloging actions documented on video and realized that I had been shooting big events with complex actions and had been ignoring ordinary but utterly constitutive fiesta

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acts such as walking, talking, and eating. The shot list grounded me, but it also had another effect, that of naming aspects of the festival that I could *not* shoot: time, for example. You can capture the passage of time by shooting a dark 6 a.m. mass and then a midday, brightly lit dance, or you can shoot clocks, but you can't video time, even though your video has an embedded time code.

If you tried to make a film on the basis of the Santa Fe shot list, you would not be telling a story; you would be
p. 285 illustrating a theme or category. Whereas a storyboard ↳ anticipates a narrative film, a shot list anticipates analysis. Since the list is neither narrative nor argumentative, it would not, unassisted, generate an engaging film or a convincing argument. The shot list implies a generic claim, namely, that rituals are made up of necessary ingredients. Leave one out and the recipe will fail, the cake will fall. Leave out an element and you will not make an engaging ritual or a compelling interpretation of a ritual. An elemental analysis of a ritual differs from more usual ways of presenting rituals, such as a summary narrative or a condensation of the mythic-historical story that is thought to explain the rite.

Another problem the Santa Fe shot list exposes is that ritual elements rarely appear in isolation. Shoot a space, and there are objects in your photo. Shoot an object, and it resides in a place. How do you distinguish an actor from an action? Can you shoot an actor who is not acting? Can you shoot an attitude except as it is embodied in a ritualist engaged in action?

Despite these limitations the elements can be useful in ritual criticism and construction as well as in the field. Scholars in organization studies are now using ritual models to diagnose the misalignment of ritual elements used in strategy workshops. They then propose alternatives, as well as formulate hypotheses for predicting success and failure.[482] The more complex the ritual, the longer the list of elements, and the longer the list, the more pairs of interactions needing analysis and diagnosis: guests and chairs, bottles of champagne and length of speeches, and so on. The best way to understand what makes a bicycle sail like the wind or merely bump along is either to build one from the pedals up or, having dismantled one down to its ball bearings, tune it up in the rebuilding process. Even if you are seldom in a position to witness the building or dismantling of a ritual, it is not that difficult to witness, even participate in, the revision or repair of one. Participating in ritual construction, diagnosis, or criticism paves the road to ritual theory more efficiently than armchair theorizing does.

Analyzing a ritual into its elements can serve theory, method, or both. One could, for example, transform the elements into planks in the platform of a theory by defining ritual as "stylized gestures and prescribed postures assumed by ritualists on the basis of scripts, written or not, while deploying symbolic objects in set-aside spaces." You could then use the definition to guide a method by instructing a camera operator to shoot actors, scripts, and objects, then instructing a video editor to select gestures and postures, emphasize stylization and recurrent patterning, and attend to boundary-crossings from ordinary into special places.

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Elements and Domains

We have now considered ritual's relation to other cultural domains (sport, theater, and music) and factored ritual into constituent elements. In table 9.2 I have assembled the two theoretical constructs to illustrate the
p. 286 cross-domain possibilities of ↳

p. 287 ↳

p. 288 ↳

p. 289 ↳

p. 290 ↳

p. 291 ↳
elemental analysis. The left column sets up the elements as axes of comparison. The columns to the right summarize some salient differences among religion (as illustrated by the Roman Catholic Mass), theater (as illustrated by Western proscenium theater), music (as illustrated by the classical music symphony), and sports (as illustrated by American baseball). To keep the comparison from become even more labyrinthine than it already is, I restrict the characterizations of music and sport, as I did in chapter 8, to Christopher Small on music, along with Michael Novak and Varda Burstyn on sport.[483]

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Table 9.2. The Elements in Four Domains

Elementsfl	Domain A: Religion, for example, Roman Catholic liturgy	Domain B: Theater, for example, Western proscenium theater	Domain C: Music, for example, classical symphony (as interpreted by Christopher Small)	Domain D: Sport, for example, professional American baseball (as interpreted by Michael Novak and Varda Burstyn)
1. Actions	ritualization elevated into liturgical action	social dramatization reimagined as theatrical performance	sounds composed into scores for musical performance	competition framed as professional game
	enactment—circular and redundant rather than narratively linear	performance narratively organized into a plot animated by characters	performance musically organized into a concert with coherence, variety, and dramatic effect but without a narratively driven plot	no plot; high and low points of excitement; outcome unknown until the end
	preparation: spiritual and/or intellectual	preparation: actor-training and rehearsal	preparation: practice, rehearsal	preparation: training, practice
	ultimate acts are metaphysical	ultimate acts are fictive and imaginative	ultimate acts are auditory and emotional	ultimate acts are physical and strategic
	purposes: praise and thanksgiving, transformation, facilitating salvation, forming ethical values, inspiring moral action	purposes: entertainment, aesthetic appreciation, cultural awareness; sometimes: education, social criticism	purposes: entertainment, aesthetic appreciation, cultural awareness; sometimes: education, social criticism tacit function (Small): construction of idealized self in an industrial society[484]	purposes: entertainment, winning, skill-building; tacit function (Burstyn): construction of masculinist ideology
2. Actors	participants who deny role-playing and who express belief along with community membership; claims to matter ultimately	actors playing roles *as if* they were real; audience members suspending disbelief	musicians playing music *as if* it were its own reality; role playing denied or minimized	competitive players playing games played *as if* they matter ultimately even though they do not
	individual emotional expression discouraged	individual emotional expression encouraged	individual emotional expression encouraged but only at appropriate times	limited range of emotions displayed on field, e.g., anger, determination, joy, sadness; only emotions appropriate to men's athletic culture
	body largely ignored and regarded as secondary	body trained and regarded as crucial	musicians' "ears" are trained along with physical skills necessary for playing a specific instrument or voice	gross motor skills (running, throwing, catching, batting) are essential

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	witnesses participating by virtue of shared values and tradition and functioning as congregation, or community	audience acting as spectators by virtue of paid admission and not integrally related to actors	audience acting mainly as listeners (secondarily as watchers) by virtue of paid admission and not integrally related to actors	ticket-buying fans watching, cheering, booing, and interacting with events on the field
	favorable reception not expressed during event; informally (but probably unreliably) indicated by compliments after the event and by continued participation	favorable reception indicated by applause or standing ovation, also by recommending to others	favorable reception indicated by applause, standing ovation, encores, also by recommending to others	favorable reception indicated by cheering and repeated attendance
	unfavorable reception sequestered or withheld	unfavorable reception indicated by silence	unfavorable reception indicated by silence	unfavorable reception indicated by booing or heckling
3. Places	cathedrals, churches, pilgrimage sites	theaters	concert halls	baseball fields
	elevated platforms, reserved places	reserved seats, better and worse views, higher and lower prices	reserved seats, better and worse views, higher and lower prices	reserved seats, better and worse views, higher and lower prices
	near the altar, places distant from altar; nonliturgical places, e.g., vestry, social halls; aisles, pews directional symbolism: up/down, east/west	performing spaces, viewing spaces, food and socializing spaces, aisles, seats, balconies, backstage, dressing rooms, lobbies	performing spaces, listening spaces, food and socializing spaces, aisles, seats, balconies, orchestra pit, lobbies	the diamond, in-bounds, infield, outfield, out of bounds, change rooms, aisles, seats, benches, dugout
4. Times	liturgical seasons, Sundays, feast days	performance season, evenings, weekends, weekdays	performance season, evenings, weekends, weekdays	playing season, weekends, weekdays
	introductory rites, liturgy of the word, liturgy of the Eucharist, concluding rite	acts, often two or three	first half, second half	innings, seven
5. Objects	costume conveys office bread, wine, water, paintings, statues, stained glass	costume conveys character sets, props	formal wear for musicians, casual to dressy clothing for audience instruments, music stands, chairs	uniform displays team name or logo along with personal identifiers (e.g., name, number); fan costumes (e.g., hats, shirts, banners) equipment (e.g., gloves, bats, uniforms)
6. Languages	formulaic language used for prayer, praise, or proclamation	dialogical language used to express plot and character	vocal song; spoken language is minimal, for introductory or contextualizing purposes only	authoritative declarations of umpires, encouragement and chatter of players in field, silence of batters, cheering and shouting of fans

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	music sometimes constitutes prayer; worship sometimes facilitates prayer and worship	music and sound effects enhance plot and character	lyrics: words set to music	musical introduction: usually the national anthem; sometimes musical interludes and postludes; no music during play
	liturgical texts from anonymous sources (scripture, tradition, or liturgical councils); also spoken or written sources from leaders selected on the basis of calling, appointments, or ordination	plays written by named playwrights employed on the basis of skill, reputation, or training	written musical scores that prescribe the playing precisely and in detail with little room for improvisation; named composers, usually deceased, selected on the basis of their classical status	records as maintained by administrative authorities, journalistic accounts in sports sections of newspapers and fan magazines
	high need for interpretation; deep resistance to criticism	moderate need for interpretation; high susceptibility to public criticism	low need for verbal interpretation; high susceptibility to public criticism	little need for interpretation; high need for quantifying performance; moderate interest in interviewing athletes and tracking careers biographically
7. Groups	sacralized hierarchy of authority: papacy, bishops, clergy, the people	production hierarchy: playwrights, producers, directors, actors, playgoers; popularity hierarchy: actors, directors	hierarchical system with conductor as operative pinnacle and composer as historical pinnacle; autocratic and/or charismatic conductor conducting a large group of musicians who consent to follow	owner-management hierarchy: owners can trade players; popularity hierarchy: baseball stars whose names are known; positions on the field: high value placed on hitters and pitchers
	theological seminaries	actor training academies	music lessons, music camps, music schools	training camps
	ecclesiastical hierarchy	star system	recording industry, sales-ranking charts	records: keeping, holding, breaking
	clergy offering homiletical interpretations of rites	drama critics writing criticism in newspapers to inform potential ticket-buyers	music critics writing criticism in newspapers to inform potential ticket-buyers	sports reporters engaging in sport journalism
	theologians writing apologetic or dogmatic theology and serving religious traditions by teaching in educational institutions	literary scholars writing interpretations of plays, playwrights, and theater history	musicologists and music historians writing books and articles, music publishers publishing music	sport historians and theorists writing histories and theories; kinesiologists studying bodily dynamics
	authorized versions are canonical	best and/or most enduring are classics	best and/or most enduring are classics	winners, championships, all-star games

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Setting domains in columns like this not only exposes the generic nature of the elements, but also risks creating the illusion that domains are easily separable. Although they may be in theory, they are not in practice. Bleeding the boundaries between dramatic and ritualistic domains characterized the theater of classical Greece, the mystery and morality plays of the Middle Ages, and experimental theater of the 1960s in North America.

Another problem is that rites, plays, concerts, and games do not exist in the abstract, only in particular forms and in specific eras. They happen in overlapping local and global cultures. Any theory-driven comparison is bound to reflect examples in a theorist's mind. No one can take into account all kinds of ritual, much less other kinds of cultural performance, so here I made choices largely for pedagogical reasons. Mainline Roman Catholic liturgy (an example of a dominant Western ritual) and mainline proscenium theater (an example of a dominant Western performance mode) have no privileged status. I chose them simply because they are familiar to many readers. The categories, "Catholic" and "proscenium," although more specific than "ritual" and "theater" in general, gloss over variants in each category, so even this more precise way of naming them risks overgeneralization inasmuch as the chart ignores differences between periods of liturgical and theatrical history and minimizes continuities between ritual and other domains for the sake of charting their respective differences.

My purpose here is simpler than such a mapping operation makes it seem. It is to engender a perspective capable of grounding a theory and method for studying ritual that attends simultaneously to its connections with and differences from other domains. But that job is not finished until the scheme is played off actual rites and performances in specific places and real times. In one respect I have oversimplified things by working with one kind of performance and one kind of ritual. In another respect I have complicated and nuanced things by suggesting that comparisons and contrasts between domains should not depend on one or two factors such as the presence or absence of an audience, or the presence or absence of belief.

An effective way to critique the sort of element-and-domain thinking I am attempting here would be to apply it to instances of cross-cultural performance such as Vodoun in nightclubs in Port-au-Prince or Japanese Noh drama performed for North American audiences. In Haiti the same actions can be performed as entertainment
p. 292 for tourists in the city and as religious practice in the villages. ↳ Observers cannot always tell from the form or content of a performance whether it is ritualistic or dramatic; one is forced to consider function and cultural setting as well. If we were to use, say, a California Buddhist liturgy and a Quebec folk dance performance as examples, the resulting typology would be somewhat different. Depending on the specific liturgies and plays that we use as examples, we can tinker infinitely with the details. In the process of studying an *actual* event, any or all of these characterizations would have to be revised. Suppose we were to specify, for instance, a post–Vatican II Mass in Amsterdam, an "American" baseball game played in twenty-first-century Japan, a classical music concert conducted by Gustavo Dudamel in Los Angeles, or *The Gospel at Colonus* as directed by Lee Breuer in 1985 in New York City. Would changing the examples in this way precipitate changes in the way we name the elements themselves? If so, we've just made a theoretical revision. How many revisions would we make before concluding that some of its assumptions are so erroneous that we need a new theory?

We have now given the domain and element metaphors a workout. Surely you are asking what good it is to be able to identify all the parts of a ritual. Let's return to our trusty, rusty bike. First, you have a better chance of

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being able to ride it if you know that the handlebars are for guiding and balancing, whereas pedals are for pushing. Second, you can order more parts. Ever go into a bike store trying to describe a thingamajig? Do you need to know the names of parts to ride a bike? Certainly not. But even if you are not mechanically inclined, it's crucial to know the functions of a few key parts: seats, handlebars, pedals, and tires. Third, you are better able to repair a bike if you can identify the function of each part. And fourth, you might—given the resources and some knowledge of bike engineering principles—be able to build a bike if you were so inclined, but you'd need to know what each part is called and what it does. To tighten, loosen, or adjust things you need to know how components interrelate, which is to say, some basic engineering principles that determine a bike's workings. It helps to know that round things roll with less effort than square or oval things. If you do, you'll understand why it's harder to pedal with a flat.

After an exercise in analytical fragmenting and fracturing, you may want to resist, objecting that all things ritualistic are inseparable, that they work together as a whole or not at all. It borders on silliness, I hear you saying, to separate actors from their actions, and surely every action takes place in space and time; it can hardly be otherwise. So why bother separating space from time or both from actions and actors? You object: After Einstein, Grimes, you should know better. After decades of ecologists insisting that all things are connected, you should know better.

Fair enough. Let us be modest in what we claim for elemental analysis. In itself, a set of elements does not constitute a theory any more than a formal definition does. You can argue with the premise of "constituents" by claiming that there aren't any or that thinking of them in the way I've laid out is misleading. You can argue
p. 293 that there are other parts, less confusing ways of naming them, or more efficient ways of ↳ clumping and separating things. You can argue for other models. But even those fond of thinking of a ritual as a "language" and wanting to formulate its "grammar," or rules for usage, are still faced with the task of identifying "parts" of speech. Ritual conceived as a language is no less a metaphor than ritual conceived as a machine or an organism, and all three lend themselves to factoring as well as rules or models for combination and recombination.

Let me be the first to admit it: The elements, by themselves, do not explain anything. On their behalf I make no substantive claim except the most obvious one: To analyze or construct a ritual, you have no choice but to break it down into its constituents. If you don't use my way, you'll use some other.

Notes

396. The cover of Grimes, *Rite out of Place* 10.1093/acprof:oso/9780195301441.001.0001 , was designed by artist Carolina Echeverria, so I am not merely indulging a fantasy.
397. One definition of "reductionism" is "a doctrine that maintains that all objects and events, their properties, and our experience and knowledge of them are made up of ultimate elements, indivisible parts." Russel Ackoff, *Redesigning the Future* (Hoboken, NJ: Wiley, 1974), 8.
398. And what are these blocks? Symbols, of course. Symbolic anthropologists tend to talk as if all components of ritual are symbolic. I no longer do so. It requires interview and observation to determine which, if any, are.
399. "The bicycle, that technological throwback from the nineteenth century, is for them a literal and metaphorical organizing principle for a new vision of the world, one that stands not simply against the most obvious form of petro-consumption, the automobile, but that heralds and celebrates—in advance of its actual arrival, and with bright little bicycle bells and radical cheers—a new, post-petroleum era." Mark Svenvold, "Send in the Clowns: Bicycle Nomads, Texas Utopianism, and the Post-Petroleum Era," *Orion*, January/February 2008, http://www.orionmagazine.org/index.php/articles/article/505.
400. Roy Rappaport describes his own theory of ritual as formalist. See Roy A. Rappaport, *Ritual and Religion in the Making of Humanity* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999), 27–28.
401. Chapter 2 of *Beginnings in Ritual Studies* was the first version of this scheme. Although I have discarded the "mapping" metaphor, putting it to another use here, I remain convinced of the worth of publishing an entire chapter consisting of questions.
402. I am making a practical recommendation, not a claim that action takes precedence over the other elements. A theory of

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ritual should not predetermine that one or another element is primary. Jonathan Smith's theorizing construes place, or placement, as primary.

403. The distinction is from Kenneth Burke, *Dramatism and Development* (Barre, MA: Clark University Press, 1972), 21.
404. Richard Schechner, *Performance Studies: An Introduction* (London: Routledge, 2002), 33.
405. Martin Buber distinguished between I-thou and I-it relations. He venerated I-thou relationships but also recognized the inevitability and necessity of I-it relations. See Martin Buber, *I and Thou*, 2nd ed. (London: Continuum, 2004 [1937]).
406. Bourdieu, *The Logic of Practice* 10.1017/CBO9780511812507 , book 1, chap. 3.
407. Ibid. 10.1017/CBO9780511812507 , 61.
408. Since Bourdieu is critical of mechanistic renditions of practice, poking fun at the positivist who recorded 480 elementary units of behavior during twenty minutes of observing his wife in the kitchen, I am aware that a Bourdovean might balk at my bicycle metaphors. But the sociologist himself talks repeatedly about "structures," so neither the presence of metaphors that sound static nor the reification of verbs into nouns necessarily signals a mechanistic theory, one that *reduces* processes to parts and construes human interactions exclusively on the model of firing engines, bumping billiard balls, or other physics-inspired models.
409. Bourdieu, *The Logic of Practice*, 68. 10.1017/CBO9780511812507
410. Ibid. 10.1017/CBO9780511812507 , 69.
411. Ibid. 10.1017/CBO9780511812507 , 77.
412. Ronald L. Grimes, "Vespers in the City of New York," online video, 2012, http://vimeo.com/ronaldlgrimes/vespersnyc.
413. Bourdieu, *The Logic of Practice*, 92. 10.1017/CBO9780511812507
414. Ibid. 10.1017/CBO9780511812507 , 94.
415. Ibid. 10.1017/CBO9780511812507 , 92.
416. "We are constituted as subjects through practice." Amy Hollywood, "Spiritual but Not Religious: The Vital Interplay between Submission and Freedom.," *Harvard Divinity Bulletin* 38, nos. 1–2 (2010): 93–115, http://www.hds.harvard.edu/news-events/harvard-divinity-bulletin/articles/spiritual-but-not-religious.
417. Ronald L. Grimes, "Caribbean Carnival: Animating Bacchanal," online video, 2012, http://vimeo.com/ronaldlgrimes/animatingbacchanal.
418. See, for instance, Susan Starr Sered, *Women as Ritual Experts: The Religious Lives of Elderly Jewish Women in Jerusalem* (Oxford: New York, 1992); Leslie A. Northup, *Ritualizing Women* (New York: Pilgrim, 1997); Marjorie Procter-Smith and Janet R. Walton, eds., *Women at Worship: Interpretations of North American Diversity* (Louisville, KY: Westminster, 1993); Björn Krondorfer, "Bodily Knowing, Ritual Embodiment, and Experimental Drama: From Regression to Transgression," *Journal of Ritual Studies* 6, no. 2 (1992): 27–38.
419. For an example of festive attitudes and stylized photographic performances see Ronald L. Grimes, "Caribbean Carnival: Animating Bacchanal," online video, 2012, http://vimeo.com/ronaldlgrimes/animatingbacchanal.
420. I find John Dewey's definition of "habit" quite acceptable: "The essence of habits is an acquired predisposition to ways, or modes, of response, not to particular acts, standing predilections and aversions, rather than bare recurrence of specific acts." Dewey, *Human Nature and Conduct: An Introduction to Social Psychology* (New York: Holt, 1922), 32.
421. The photo album: Ronald L. Grimes, "Highgate United Church: A Photographic Study," online photo album, 2012, https://picasaweb.google.com/110779451079822593112/HighgateUnitedChurchAPhotographicStudy. The video album: Ronald L. Grimes, "Highgate United Church of Canada," online video album, 2010, https://vimeo.com/album/1510075.
422. Ronald L. Grimes, "The Deconsecration of a Canadian Church: Highgate United, 1834–2010," online video, 2012, http://vimeo.com/ronaldlgrimes/highgate-deconsecration.
423. See Barry Stephenson, "Highgate United," online video, 2011, https://vimeo.com/album/1510075/video/18807637.
424. The Mary Webb Centre, http://marywebbcentre.ca/.
425. See Qibla Locator at http://www.qiblalocator.com/.
426. If you think not, see Marc Connelly and William Keighley, dir., *The Green Pastures* (Warner Bros. Pictures, 1936).
427. The phrase belongs to Edward T. Hall, *The Hidden Dimension* (New York: Anchor, 1973).
428. See Alfonso Ortiz, *The Tewa World: Space, Time, Being, and Becoming in a Pueblo Society* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1972).
429. See Cele L. Otnes and Tina M. Lowrey, eds., *Contemporary Consumption Rituals* (Mahwah, NJ: Erlbaum, 2003).
430. On ritual and the environment see Philip P. Arnold and Ann Grodzins Gold, eds., *Sacred Landscapes and Cultural Politics: Planting a Tree* (Burlington, VT: Ashgate, 2001); J. Peter Brosius, "Anthropological Engagements with Environmentalism," *Current Anthropology* 40 (1999), 277–309 10.1086/200019 ; E. N. Anderson, *Ecologies of the Heart: Emotion, Belief, and the Environment* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1996); Rappaport, *Ritual and Religion in the Making of Humanity*. 10.1017/CBO9780511814686

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431. Part of this section is modified from Ronald L. Grimes, “Jonathan Smith's Theory of Ritual,” *Religion* 29 (1999): 261–273. 10.1006/reli.1998.0162
432. Jonathan Z. Smith, *To Take Place: Toward Theory in Ritual* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1987), 96. The epigraph for the chapter, “To Take Place,” is from Stéphane Mallarmé.
433. Ibid., 104.
434. A danger of this slippage is the overextended metaphor. For example, in *American Sacred Space* Chidester and Linenthal conclude their introduction by brandishing an analogy with astonishing implications. “In an important sense,” they claim, “the authors of the essays collected in this book have rediscovered America. Not content with the guidebooks, formulas, and comforts of academic tourism, the authors have risked the uncharted dangers of exploration to see America new.” A reader's “itinerary” through the book is construed as the equivalent of a pilgrimage to sacred sites. See David Chidester and Edward T. Linenthal, eds., *American Sacred Space* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1995), 31.
435. Smith, *To Take Place*, 112.
436. Ibid., 108.
437. Ibid., 109.
438. Ibid., 26.
439. Burke's formulation of the synecdochic relation between scene (place) and agent (actor) is, in my opinion, more balanced and thus more acceptable. See Kenneth Burke, *Grammar of Motives* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1969), chapter 1. Also see Appendix 17: Kenneth Burke's Dramatistic Categories.
440. Sarah Horton, “The Santa Fe Fiesta, Reinvented: Sacralizing Ties to a Disappearing Homeland” (PhD diss., University of New Mexico, 2003), 23.
441. See Wilson, *The Myth of Santa Fe*, 232–273.
442. Time and space are among the categories of Aristotle and Immanuel Kant. In their usages, categories are not pigeonholes for classifying things but inescapable qualities of anything and everything that exists. For Aristotle the categories included substance (e.g., throne, chair), quantity (e.g., three hundred years, two princesses), quality (e.g., hot, red), relation (e.g., causal, reciprocal), place (e.g., at home, in the field), time (e.g., fiesta time, Saturday), posture (e.g., mounted horseback, kneeling), state (e.g., believes in Mary, has armor on), action (e.g., raising fist, shouting), passivity/passion (e.g., being chosen, being out of work). For Aristotle the categories are characteristics of the real world (hence, his “realism”); for Kant, of the mind that perceives the world (hence, his “conceptualism”). See Aristotle, *The Categories*, trans. E. M. Edghill (Adelaide, South Australia: University of Adelaide Library). Also see Amie Thomasson, “Categories,” *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, http://plato.stanford.edu/archives/win2012/entries/categories/ (accessed June 30, 2013).
443. See Grimes, “Rituals and Games.”
444. See Whitehouse, *Modes of Religiosity*.
445. See, for instance, Appendix 14: Phases of the Roman Catholic Liturgy.
446. See, for instance, Service Builder, http://servicebuilder.net/. Also, for a discussion of Pentecostalism's resort to computer-scheduled worship, watch Ronald L. Grimes, “Improvisation and Pentecostalism: An Interview with Adam Stewart,” online video, 2011, http://vimeo.com/ronaldlgrimes/improvisation-and-pentecostalism.
447. Most ritual accounts don’t make good stories. Like dreams, however good they are to undergo, they are not so good to listen to.
448. Ronald L. Grimes, “Ritual Improvisation and the Disposition of Cremation Ashes in the Netherlands: An Interview with Meike Heessels,” online video, 2011, http://vimeo.com/ronaldlgrimes/cremationashes.
449. A good example is Ross Katz, dir., *Taking Chance*, HBO Films, 2009. The entire film is a ritual for repatriating a soldier's body.
450. Parts of this section are adapted from Ronald L. Grimes, “Ritual,” in “Key Words in Material Religion,” special issue, *Material Religion: The Journal of Objects, Art and Belief* 7, no. 1 (2011).
451. Angelico Chávez, *La Conquistadora: The Autobiography of an Ancient Statue* (Paterson, NJ: St. Anthony Guild, 1954).
452. It is both amusing and revealing to watch some “object speeches” on YouTube.
453. Ronald L. Grimes, “Ritual Criticism of Field Excavations and Museum Displays,” in *Ritual Criticism: Case Studies in Its Practice, Essays on Its Theory*, 51–70 (Waterloo, ON: Ritual Studies International, 2010).
454. In 1867 Karl Marx wrote:
    A commodity appears, at first sight, a very trivial thing, and easily understood. Its analysis shows that it is, in reality, a very queer thing, abounding in metaphysical subtleties and theological niceties. So far as it is a value in use, there is nothing mysterious about it, whether we consider it from the point of view that by its properties it is capable of satisfying human wants, or from the point that those properties are the product of human labour. It is as clear as noon-day, that man, by his industry, changes the forms of the materials furnished by Nature, in such a way as to make them useful to him. The form of wood, for instance, is altered, by making a table out of it. Yet, for all that, the table continues to be that common, every-day thing, wood. But, so soon as it steps forth as a commodity, it is changed into something transcendent. It not

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only stands with its feet on the ground, but, in relation to all other commodities, it stands on its head, and evolves out of its wooden brain grotesque ideas, far more wonderful than "table-turning" ever was. In order, therefore, to find an analogy, we must have recourse to the mist-enveloped regions of the religious world. In that world the productions of the human brain appear as independent beings endowed with life, and entering into relation both with one another and the human race. So it is in the world of commodities with the products of men's hands. This I call the Fetishism which attaches itself to the products of labour, so soon as they are produced as commodities, and which is therefore inseparable from the production of commodities.
Karl Marx, "The Fetishism of Commodities and the Secret Thereof," *Capital*, vol. 1 (1867), http://www.marxists.org/archive/marx/works/1867-c1/ch01.htm.

Marx's idea has been amplified in various strands of Marxist thought. No one makes the ritual nature of contemporary commoditization more transparent than Guy Debord (1931–1994), who wrote:
Consumers are filled with religious fervor for the sovereign freedom of commodities whose use has become an end in itself. Waves of enthusiasm for particular products are propagated by all the communications media. A film sparks a fashion craze; a magazine publicizes night spots which in turn spin off different lines of products. The proliferation of faddish gadgets reflects the fact that as the mass of commodities becomes increasingly absurd, absurdity itself becomes a commodity. Trinkets such as key chains which come as free bonuses with the purchase of some luxury product, but which end up being traded back and forth as valued collectibles in their own right, reflect a mystical self-abandonment to commodity transcendence. Those who collect the trinkets that have been manufactured for the sole purpose of being collected are accumulating commodity indulgences—glorious tokens of the commodity's real presence among the faithful. Reified people proudly display the proofs of their intimacy with the commodity. Like the old religious fetishism, with its convulsionary raptures and miraculous cures, the fetishism of commodities generates its own moments of fervent exaltation. All this is useful for only one purpose: producing habitual submission.
Guy Debord, "Unity and Division within Appearances," trans. Ken Knabb, *The Society of the Spectacle*, vol. 3 (1967), http://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Society_of_the_Spectacle (accessed June 30, 2013).

455. Ronald L. Grimes, "A Brush with Silence," online video, 2012, http://vimeo.com/ronaldlgrimes/brush-with-silence.
456. The video implicitly raises the question: how much artistic license should we grant a scholar? By speeding up the action and laying unexpected music beneath it, I am commenting on, not merely presenting, the workshop. Is it okay to interpret using images and sounds rather than words on a printed page? George Kordis, the iconographer, responded positively with gusto to the video. The students were divided, most saying they enjoyed the humor and irony, but a few saying they would have preferred a soundtrack containing the ambient chatter, silence, or Orthodox chant. I justify my interpretation by calling attention to repeated cell-phone checking and the howling wind, but is this sufficient warrant? To facilitate a comparison and reflection on the editing-interpreting process, there is a fifteen-minute rough-cut version with no music, transitions or adjustments to volume and lighting: "Icon-Writing with George Kordis: A Rough-Cut," online video, 2013, http://vimeo.com/ronaldlgrimes/kordisiconroughcut.
457. The Seven Ecumenical Councils of the Undivided Church, "Epitome of the Definition of the Iconoclastic Counciliabulum, Held in Constantinople, a.d. 754," http://www.fordham.edu/halsall/source/icono-cncl754.asp (accessed June 30, 2013).
458. See Margaret Olin, *Touching Photographs* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2012).
459. Hans Pool and Maaik Krijgsman, dirs., *Looking for an Icon*, 55 min., black and white, United States, 2007.
460. Quoted in Hans Pool and Maaik Krijgsman, dir., *Looking for an Icon* (Icarus Films, 2007).
461. Henry VIII's Wives, "Iconic Moments of the Twentieth Century," http://h8w.net/work/im.html (accessed June 30, 2013). For other refractions of the photo see "Covers and Citations," http://search.it.online.fr/covers/?m=1968 (accessed June 30, 2013).
462. The image is easily available on the Internet by conducting an image search using "Eddie Adams" and "Nguyen Ngoc" as search terms.
463. Ronald L. Grimes, "Ritual Creativity, Improvisation, and the Arts," online video album, 2012, https://vimeo.com/album/1524902.
464. "A Vulnerable Moment in Vocal Improvisation," online video, 2012, http://vimeo.com/ronaldlgrimes/vulnerablemoment.
465. I'm riffing off Scott-Grimes, "O Mother, Where Art Thou?"
466. See, for instance, Bridget Doak, "Effects of Shamanic Drumming on Anxiety, Mood, States of Consciousness, Imagery, and Brain Patterns in Adult Subjects," *Dissertation Abstracts International*, 67 (2007) #9-A, 3215; Michael J. Winkelman, *Shamans, Priests and Witches*, Anthropological Research Papers no. 44, Arizona State University, 1992.
467. For the original claim see Alfred A. Tomatis, *The Conscious Ear: My Life of Transformation through Listening* (Paris: Station Hill, 1991). For the popularized version see Don Campbell, *The Mozart Effect: Tapping the Power of Music to Heal the Body,*

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Strengthen the Mind, and Unlock the Creative Spirit (New York: HarperCollins, 2001 [1997]). For a critique see C. F. Chabris, "Prelude or Requiem for the 'Mozart Effect'?" *Nature* 400 (1999): 826–827. 10.1038/23608

468. Katherine Creath and Gary E. Schwartz, "Measuring Effects of Music, Noise, and Healing Energy Using a Seed Germination Bioassay," *Journal of Alternative and Complementary Medicine* 10, no. 1 (2004): 113–122. 10.1089/107555304322849039
469. See Daniel J. Levitin, *This Is Your Brain on Music: The Science of a Human Obsession* (New York: Penguin, 2007), and Charles D. Laughlin, John McManus, and Eugene G. d'Aquili, *Brain, Symbol and Experience: Toward a Neurophenomenology of Human Consciousness* (Boston: Shambhala, 1990).
470. The key text in explaining how performative utterances work is J. L. Austin, *How to Do Things with Words*, 2nd ed. (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1975).
471. Listen to Patrick Evans and Siobhán Garrigan discussing paperless worship: Ronald L. Grimes, "Enacting What We Say We Believe," online video, 2012, http://vimeo.com/ronaldlgrimes/we-say-we-believe; "A Teaching Space for Liturgical Formation," online video, 2012, http://vimeo.com/ronaldlgrimes/teaching-liturgical-formation.
472. Ronald L. Grimes, "St. Lydia's," online video, 2012, http://vimeo.com/ronaldlgrimes/st-lydias.
473. Notice the metaphor-making going on here. Just as I talked about ritual beliefs as if they are contained "inside" ritual actors, now I'm talking as if the social bonds of ritual are "outside" and "between" these actors, and as if social structures, like buildings, can be left "standing." Of course, none of these claims is literally true, but you have no choice: Pick your metaphors and pay your dues.
474. A. L. Kroeber and Clyde Kluckhohn, "Culture: A Critical Review of Concepts and Definitions," *Peabody Museum of American Archeology and Ethnology Papers* 47, no. 1 (1952): 181. This definition attempts to condense the hundreds reviewed in this book, which is the best single source for other definitions.
475. Geertz, *The Interpretation of Cultures*.
476. Fred Plog and Daniel G. Bates, *Cultural Anthropology*, 2nd ed. (New York: Random House, 1988).
477. Ronald L. Grimes, "Caribbean Carnival: Judging the Junior Parade," online video, 2012, http://vimeo.com/ronaldlgrimes/junior-parade; "Caribbean Carnival: The Toronto Revellers," online video, 2012, http://vimeo.com/ronaldlgrimes/revellers.
478. Patricia Reaney, "Average Cost of U.S. Wedding Hits $27,021," Reuters, March 23, 2012, http://www.reuters.com/article/2012/03/23/us-wedding-costs-idUSBRE82M11O20120323. The author is citing a study conducted by TheKnow.com and WeddingChannel.com.
479. An often quoted figure is $6,500, but the amount is dated and includes only fees paid directly to a funeral director.
480. Little is written about the economics of the Santa Fe Fiesta. The most thorough treatment of the financial impact of Santa Fe's several festivals is Romella S. Glorioso and Laurence A. G. Moss, "Santa Fe, a Fading Dream: 1986 Profile and 2005 Postscript," in *The Amenity Migrants: Seeking and Sustaining Mountains and Their Cultures*, ed. Laurence A. G. Moss (Cambridge, MA: CABI).
481. For instance, Sobonfu Somé, a teacher of African spirituality in the West, says she is a keeper of rituals for the Dagara Tribe of Burkina Faso. See http://www.spiritualityandpractice.com/teachers/teachers.php?id=300 (accessed June 30, 2013).
482. See, for example, Gerry Johnson, Shameen Prashantham, Steven W. Floyd, and Nicole Bourque, "The Ritualization of Strategy Workshops," *Organization Studies* 31, no. 12 (2010): 1589–1618, doi: 10.1177/0170840610376146, http://oss.sagepub.com/content/31/12/1589 (accessed June 30, 2013).
483. The characterization of sport's tacit function is largely that of Varda Burstyn, *The Rites of Men*. She demonstrates that contemporary sport amounts to the ritualization of a masculinist ideology. She and Christopher Small are critics, employing the notion of ritual not merely to analyze but to mount critiques of music and sport. Her use of the idea of ritual, like his, works like a crowbar for prying the lid off a cultural activity and exposing what is inside or underneath. Neither writer is entirely happy with what she or he sees. Since they utilize the idea of ritual as a key to comprehending other kinds of action, the issue for them is not *whether* ritual has a connection with music or sport but *how* that connection is understood.
484. I have included tacit functions in this column because they are such a prominent part of Christopher Small's argument. One could do the same for the other columns by invoking other critics.

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